

ome more glimpses from the
dipur Tiger Reserve.”
With the majestic elephants at
Mudumalai Tiger Reserve.”
What a delight to meet the
derful Bomman and Belli.
g with Bommi and Raghu.”

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

examined. "The motive behind the killing is yet to be ascertained, and all possible angles are being examined. We are also trying to establish whether a single person or more than one person was involved in the attack," the officer said.

Police have registered an FIR in connection with the incident and formed multiple teams to identify and apprehend the accused.

Investigators are scanning CCTV footage, collecting forensic evidence and questioning people who may have witnessed the incident or have information about the accused.

Head of the Department of Psychiatry at IHBAS submitted a report by letter dated December 22, 2025, informing the Commission that an External Inquiry Committee had been constituted. The committee's report found several gaps in the treatment protocol and recommended remedial measures. However, the Commission noted that the report was silent on the question of compensation for the mother, prompting a fresh show-cause notice.

The notice was issued under the hand and seal of the Commission and signed by Joint Registrar (Law) Indrajeet Kumar. Records from the NHRC's case tracking system confirm the show-cause notice as the third formal action taken in the case, following the initial notice and the reminder.

Separately, questions are being raised over delays in filling the post of Director at IHBAS. The Delhi government had advertised the vacancy, with the last date for submitting applications set as April 10, 2026. According to reliable sources, around ten candidates from institutions across the country have applied for the position.

PUBLIC NOTICE
The public is informed that a deed of sale was executed in the name of Mrs. Rubi, wife of Veerpal, resident of Sadarpur, Sector 45, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, by Mr. Pramod Singh, son of Chhitar Singh, resident of Sadarpur, Sector 45, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, located in Kharsa numbers 264m, 265m, and 266m of village Salarpur Khadar, measuring 50 square yards. Its plot number is 101, which was registered with the Sub-Registrar II on July 13, 2026, in the same volume number 15422, pages 345 to 360, serial number 5902. This deed has been lost. If anyone finds this document, please contact mobile number **8920285006**.



NEW OKHLA INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Main Administrative Building, Sector-96, Noida,
G.B. Nagar (U.P.) website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited for the following job from eligible bidders who are registered on Prahari Software, these may be uploaded by the dates specified below, and the received E-tenders will be opened on the dates indicated against them. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) Fresh-Tender Work:

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
1	66/GM/SM (WC-9) /ET /2026-27	Emergency Work (Fencing with RCC post vacant Noida land for safety of land of different Village and Sector of work Circle-9) Noida.	64.40
2	72/GM/SM (WC-9) /ET /2026-27	M/o Road (C/o RCC Central Verge on 45.00 mtr. wide road in between Sector 131 and 133) Noida.	92.10
3	30/GM/SM (WC-10) /ET/25-26	D/o & M/o Village (Providing and Laying of CC on damage roads & repair of drains at different location in Village – Nalgarah) Noida.	62.99
4	77/GM/SM (WC-9) /ET /2026-27	D/o Village (Repair and Maintenance of boundary wall 5% plot, cc road MS Jaal work in Village Sultanpur) Noida.	72.92
5	78/GM/SM (WC-9) /ET /2026-27	D/o Village (M/o Sports Ground and Boundary wall in Village Raipur) Noida.	31.49
6	49/GM/SM (WC-7) /ET/2026-27	M/o Road (M/o footpath work at Block-A and B, Phase-II) Noida.	49.26
7	50/SM(WC-7) /ET /2026-27	D/o Village (C/o Verandah, Room and toilet in Shamshan Ghat of Village-Yakubpur), Noida.	31.93
8	51/GMSM (WC-7)/ET /2026-27	M/o Drain (M/o Drain and C/o Culvert in Block-A and B Hosier complex) Noida.	50.77

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 17.08.2026 to 31.08.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 01.09.2026 at 11.00 AM.

B) Re -Tender Work:

Sl. No.	Jobs No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
9	20/GM/SM (WC-10)/ET/2026-27	Repair & Maintenance work of Community Center Sector-154, Noida. (As per Gram Chaupal Request).	69.71
10	23/GM/SM (WC-10) /ET/2026-27	M/o Road (Providing and Laying Thermoplastic Compound, P/F road Stud, Flexible Median Markers, Linear Delinator Systems and other safety related work on 45.00 mtr, Sector-147, 148,) Noida.	70.31
11	03/GM/SM (WC-9) /ET /2026-27	Theme Painting of walls in Noida for Swachh Survekshan 2025-26 WC-8 and 9 Area, Noida.	55.86
12	60/GM/SM (WC-9)/ET /2026-27	D/o Sector-94 & 94A (C/o Cremation Platform, Shed and renovate of wooden storage Hall and other Maintenance work in Antim Niwas Sector-94A) Noida.	89.00

The above tenders can be uploaded from dated 17.08.2026 to 24.08.2026 up to 5.00 PM. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated 25.08.2026 at 11.00 AM.

**General Manager (Civil)
NOIDA**

CLEAN, GREEN, SECURE, SAFE NOIDA

RWA members of Pocket A-13 welcomed the MLA and expressed their happiness over the development work carried out in the society. They also conveyed their hope that the remaining pending works would be completed in the coming days.

The visit provided an opportunity for the MLA to interact directly with residents and RWA representatives, understand their concerns and review the progress of development works. Sahi Ram Pehalwan assured the residents that their pending demands would be considered and necessary work would be undertaken soon.

JNU VC rejects allegations of irregularity in recruitment, promotion

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU) Vice Chancellor Santishree Dhulipudi Pandit has rejected allegations by the JNUSU and JNUTA of irregularities in faculty recruitment and promotions at the university, calling them 'propaganda'.

"Despite the most transparent, record recruitments, especially of the SC/ST and the OBC in the university in the last four and a half years of my term as VC, I have been made the target of a vicious campaign by the JNUSU and

JNUTA. No evidence, only fake propaganda," Pandit said in a statement.

This comes in light of the demands made by JNU Students' Union and JNU Teachers' Association, asking for the removal of the VC and an independent, time-bound inquiry into alleged irregularities in faculty recruitment and promotions at the university.

According to the administration, JNU has conducted more than 400 interviews and filled over 200 positions since February 2022, with nearly 70 per cent of the appointments belonging to

reserved and marginalised categories. It also said no complaints had been received from candidates regarding the interviews.

The administration defended the composition of the selection committees, saying they comprise three domain experts, a visitor's nominee, the concerned dean and the vice chancellor. The academic council subsequently approves the names finalised by the selection committee, it said.

The university further said its Internal Quality Assurance Cell (IQAC) verifies candidates' qualifications and pub-



lication claims as part of the screening process but has no role in the final selection during interviews.

The JNUSU, in a press

release, said recent media reports had raised concerns regarding candidates allegedly being brought back into the selection process despite

being rejected by subject experts for not meeting mandatory UGC eligibility criteria.

In a separate charter of demands issued on Thursday, the JNUTA claimed that an investigation based on RTI responses, official records and executive council dissent notes had found that at least seven faculty members were appointed in violation of UGC norms.

The administration, however, said the screening process involved the verification of publication claims, particularly in humanities and social sciences, where

publication databases and verification mechanisms can be more complex. It said this explained instances where candidates shortlisted by centres did not reach the interview stage or candidates initially not selected were subsequently called for interviews.

On the matter of promotions, the university said nearly 250 Career Advancement Scheme (CAS) applications had been processed since February 2022, including some that had remained pending since 2006. It described this as the largest number of CAS pro-

motions since JNU was founded. The administration also rejected concerns around familial or supervisory connections, saying marital or familial ties by themselves could neither be treated as a qualification nor a disqualification for employment. It also said being a former student of a supervisor did not, by itself, establish a violation of UGC publication requirements.

The JNU administration maintained that the recruitment and promotion processes had been conducted fairly and in accordance with established procedures.

CISF personnel suspended after woman alleges secret photography in metro

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) personnel has been suspended and placed under departmental inquiry after a woman accused him of secretly photographing her inside a Delhi Metro coach. The incident escalated into a scuffle and went viral on social media.



reportedly found in his phone's gallery.

A video of the incident, which quickly spread online, shows passengers repeatedly demanding that the CISF personnel delete the images from his phone. As the argument grew heated, the personnel allegedly tried to exit the coach, but passengers blocked him, leading to a physical scuffle inside the train.

Several passengers who witnessed the incident claimed that the CISF personnel pulled out his service pistol and pointed it toward commuters before stepping onto the platform. However, Metro Police sources denied that any such incident involving the weapon occurred.

Despite the denial, the viral video has triggered widespread concern over the confrontation and the

conduct of the security personnel involved.

According to CISF sources, the personnel has been suspended from duty, and a departmental inquiry has been initiated to examine the allegations. Metro Police said their officers reached the spot after receiving a PCR call regarding the disturbance. However, the woman at the centre of the allegations did not file a formal complaint with police.

Police said they have informed CISF authorities about the accusations made by the woman and other passengers, who alleged that the personnel had taken her photographs without consent. Officials said further action in the matter would depend on the findings of the CISF's internal inquiry and whether a formal complaint

is eventually filed.

The incident has renewed scrutiny over the conduct of security personnel deployed across the Delhi Metro network, which sees CISF forces stationed at stations and occasionally travelling in coaches as part of security protocols. The viral nature of the video, showing an armed security official in a physical altercation with civilian passengers, has amplified public attention on the case.

Metro Police have not disclosed the identity of the CISF personnel involved, citing the ongoing departmental inquiry. Officials said the woman's decision not to file a formal complaint means the case currently rests primarily on the CISF's internal investigation, though this could change if she or other witnesses come forward with a

formal complaint later.

The alleged use of a service weapon during the confrontation remains a point of dispute, with passenger accounts and police statements offering conflicting versions of events. Police have maintained their position that no such incident took place, even as several passengers who were present continue to claim otherwise.

CISF personnel deployed on the Delhi Metro network are tasked with maintaining security at stations and inside trains, a responsibility that includes monitoring for suspicious activity and ensuring passenger safety.

The suspension of the personnel involved in Sunday's incident suggests the force is treating the allegations seriously, pending the outcome of its inquiry.

Water bill surcharge waived till March 2027



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has extended its 100 per cent waiver on Late Payment Surcharge (LPSC) for outstanding water bills till March 31, 2027, giving consumers a final opportunity to clear old dues, according to a statement from the Delhi Jal Board (DJB).

The scheme, applicable to both domestic and non-domestic consumers, has already benefited 5,27,514 consumers, with ₹3,261 crore in LPSC waived so far.

The DJB has collected ₹815.84 crore in principal amount from domestic and non-domestic consumers under the scheme, helping recover genuine dues while easing the financial burden on residents.

The waiver scheme covers 14.09 lakh domestic consumers and 70,312 commercial consumers across the city, offering a large section of Delhi residents and business establishments a chance to settle old outstanding water bills without paying accumulated surcharges.

Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh said the extension reflected the Government's attempt to balance financial discipline with sensitivity toward ordinary consumers.

He said an old water bill often remains a source of worry for families for years, as the surcharge keeps adding to the amount, making it increasingly difficult to clear. He said the Government wanted to give people a genuine opportunity to pay only the principal amount and leave the surcharge burden behind.

Singh said the relief had been kept simple and transparent, with consumers not required to pay anything beyond what they actually owed. He said that if the principal amount is paid, the entire LPSC amount would be waived, calling it real relief for

consumers while also strengthening the Jal Board's finances in a responsible manner. The Minister clarified that the extended deadline should not be viewed as an open-ended relaxation.

According to the Delhi Jal Board's order, the waiver has been extended only till March 31, 2027, and no further extension will be granted beyond this date. Singh appealed to consumers with pending water dues to use this window to clear the principal amount and close the matter permanently, describing it as the final opportunity.

The Delhi Jal Board has directed its field offices to give wide publicity to the settlement scheme and inform consumers about the LPSC waiver available against payment of the principal amount. The scheme's extension comes as the Jal Board continues efforts to recover long-pending dues from consumers across the city while reducing the financial strain caused by years of accumulated surcharge.

Officials said the waiver was designed to encourage voluntary settlement of old bills rather than relying solely on enforcement action against defaulters.

With the scheme's reach extending to over 14.7 lakh consumers combined across domestic and commercial categories, officials said field offices would now focus on identifying and reaching out to consumers who have not yet taken advantage of the waiver. The Government's messaging has centred on framing the extension as a final settlement window, with officials reiterating that the March 2027 deadline is firm and will not be pushed further.

The scheme forms part of the Delhi Jal Board's broader push to clear outstanding dues while offering relief to consumers who have struggled with mounting late payment charges on their water bills.

Karmajeevi Awaas Yojana flats booked within hours

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

More than half of the 1,218 flats offered under the DDA Karmajeevi Awaas Yojana 2026 were booked within hours of launch on Independence Day, with all 1-BHK units selling out completely, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) said.



The scheme, launched under the guidance of Lieutenant Governor and DDA Chairman Taranjit Singh Sandhu, opened for bookings on August 15 through a First Come, First Serve basis. By the end of Day 1, 661 flats, over 50 per cent of the total inventory, had been booked, with particularly strong demand in the 1-BHK category.

DDA officials said the response reflected growing confidence among homebuyers in the authority's affordable, ready-to-move housing initiatives and highlighted rising demand for DDA housing in Narela specifically. Officials said the response also pointed to a strong preference among working professionals for affordable 1-BHK units.

The scheme offers 1,218 ready-to-move flats at Pocket-11, Sector AI-A4 in Narela, with a flat 25 per cent discount across categories. After the discount, prices start at ₹s 33.40 lakh for 1-BHK flats, ₹s 75.55 lakh for 2-BHK flats and ₹s 1.065 crore for 3-BHK flats. The scheme has been designed for serving and retired gov-

Govt to roll out paperless e-Cabinet system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning to implement an e-Cabinet system for online, paperless meetings of the Council of Ministers to speed up decision-making and enhance administrative efficiency. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has held detailed discussions with experts from the National Informatics Centre (NIC) to introduce a paperless e-Cabinet system, aimed at making Cabinet meetings more secure, faster and fully digital.

The proposed system will allow all Cabinet notes, meeting agendas, annexures, decisions and minutes to be prepared, shared and accessed digitally by con-



cerned officials, eliminating dependence on paper.

The Chief Minister said the Delhi Government was committed to using modern technology for administrative reforms and improving governance and that the e-Cabinet system would speed up decision-making, strengthen document secu-

rity and improve coordination between departments.

The Chief Minister said effective use of technology in governance was the need of the hour. She said the Government aimed to build a system that simplifies processes, enables faster decisions and allows continuous monitoring of how

those decisions are implemented.

A key feature of the proposed system, according to the Chief Minister, is tiered digital access for ministers and officers based on their responsibilities. Authorised users, including ministers, the Chief Secretary, Principal Secretaries and departmental secretaries, will only be able to access documents relevant to their role, a measure intended to strengthen the security of confidential information.

She said the system would allow the entire process of submitting Cabinet notes, examining them, granting approvals, forwarding them to concerned officials and preserving them as records to be carried out online.

Police arrest two in Lal Bagh murder case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 550-km interstate hunt led to the arrest of two men from Uttarakhand in connection with the killing of a 27-year-old man in northwest Delhi's Lal Bagh area.

Accused Aman alias Mulla (26) and Anuj alias Moni (20) were apprehended from a spot near Chappar Toll Naka while they were travelling in a rented car.

Officials said Anuj was also wanted in another murder case registered at the Jahangirpuri police station. The rented car and two mobile phones were seized from their possession.

"The incident took place on

August 12 in the Lal Bagh jhuggi area of Azadpur, where police received PCR calls regarding a stabbing and firing. The injured man was rushed to the Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial (BJRM) Hospital, where doctors declared him dead," a senior police officer said.

According to police, the victim had suffered firearm injuries, with entry and exit wounds in the abdomen and back, besides a stab injury on his back. An eyewitness told police that he and the victim were near his house that night. Around 11:30 pm, they went to a shop where they encountered Aman and another person.

An altercation broke out



between the victim and the accused, following which Aman and his associate allegedly threatened the two men before leaving the spot.

The accused allegedly returned when the victim and the eyewitness were heading back to their locality and opened fire. While the eyewitness managed to escape, the victim sustained gunshot as well as stab

injuries, the officer said.

A case was registered at the Adarsh Nagar police station, a team formed and an investigation launched. Police said intelligence inputs indicated that the accused had moved towards Haridwar in Uttarakhand. A team that was subsequently sent to the hill state tracked their movements across locations.

"The accused kept changing their locations in an attempt to evade arrest. Police officials correlated technical inputs with field intelligence and followed their movement across state borders before intercepting them near Chappar Toll Naka after covering around 550 km," the officer said.

Delhi zoo plans return of zebras, giraffes under major modernisation drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Zebras and giraffes are set to make a long-awaited return to the Delhi zoo, with the animals expected to be brought from an African country after new specialised, glass-fronted enclosures were constructed for them as part of a major modernisation plan.

The striped zebra has been absent from the zoo for nearly 15 years, while giraffes have not been seen there for around 11 years. An official said both species are part of the zoo's current and future animal collection plan and will be introduced only after their enclosures are ready.

He said, "Zebra and giraffe are expected to come from

an African country, and the animals will be brought to the zoo only after their species-specific glass enclosures are constructed."

The modernisation plan envisages creating a larger collection of wildlife and introducing modern facilities for both animals and visitors. The zoo currently has around 93 species, while the plan is to increase the number to about 109, he mentioned.

The zoo's last zebra died on April 30, 2011, while its last giraffe, named Ankita, died in June 2015 after suffering a heart attack, according to the official. The zoo had more than 130 species around three decades ago, but the number has since declined to around 93

species, comprising nearly 1,245 animals.

The proposed collection would include zebras and giraffes as well as cheetahs, New World monkeys and mouse deer. The plan is aimed at diversifying the zoo's collection and providing visitors an opportunity to see species that have not been housed there for several years, he shared.

According to the official, both options for acquiring exotic animals would be explored in the future. Such animals are expected to be brought mainly through gifts or exchanges with foreign zoos, while other species could also be sourced from zoos within the country and abroad.

Around Rs 3.75 crore has



been earmarked for bringing animals from different zoos in India and abroad, the official said. The move is part of a broader modernisation exercise for which an expenditure of around Rs 400 crore has been approved.

A key feature of the modernisation plan is the proposed use of laminated glass in several animal enclosures, the official said. Species-specific enclosure designs are being planned, with glass frontage envisaged to allow

visitors a clearer view of animals while maintaining an appropriate safety barrier.

The glass will be used at selected enclosures, including those for lions, tigers, leopards, bears and wolves, among others, he said.

The laminated glass will provide visitors with a closer visual experience while ensuring that animals remain separated from them, he said, and added that the design will also take into account the behavioural and habitat requirements of individual species rather than adopting a common enclosure model for all animals.

The official said moats and other safety measures are also proposed around several enclosures. Moats will be constructed or

improved around enclosures for animals such as lions, tigers and other potentially dangerous species, along with other protective arrangements.

The modernisation plan also envisages changes in the way visitors move around the zoo. Separate routes are proposed for buses, cars, two-wheelers and pedestrians to improve movement and reduce congestion inside the premises.

According to him, the entry area from Mathura Road to the zoo would also be improved, with several facilities proposed along the route. Separate access arrangements and visitor amenities are being planned to make movement within the zoo more convenient.

New facilities for visitors, including toilets, are also proposed under the project, the official said. The plan further includes a hospital for animals and new enclosures to strengthen veterinary and animal-care infrastructure.

The official said the modernisation work has already begun and will be carried out in phases. The overall focus would be on providing better habitats and care facilities for animals while also making the zoo more accessible and engaging for visitors.

The return of zebras and giraffes is expected to be among the more visible additions under the plan, offering visitors a chance to see the two species at the zoo again after a gap of several years, he added.

Farmers’ march to Delhi halted at Khanauri border



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Khanauri/Jind

The Haryana Police prevented farmers from proceeding to Delhi as part of their 228-km “Kisan Bachao Padyatra” on Sunday by setting up multi-layer barricading along the Khanauri inter-State border point.

Three rounds of talks between representatives of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha (Non-Political), which was spearheading the foot march, and Haryana Government officials remained inconclusive.

SKM (Non-Political) leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal rejected the officials’ offer of a meeting with the Haryana chief minister and insisted on arranging an appointment with the

Union agriculture minister to discuss their main issue—the proposed India-US trade deal. After police did not allow them to proceed to Delhi, Dallewal announced that the farmers would sit at the Khanauri border point peacefully.

The SKM (Non-Political) had given a call for the “Kisan Bachao Padyatra” from Data Singh Wala village on the Haryana-Punjab border to Jantar Mantar in Delhi, culminating in a farmers’ panchayat in the national Capital on August 29. The march was planned against the proposed India-US trade deal and to press for a legal guarantee for procuring crops at the minimum support price (MSP).

CAG audit exposes stark gaps in railway...

According to the report, water samples collected from water coolers tested positive for E coli at eight stations across four railway zones. These included Coimbatore and Palakkad Junction in Southern Railway; Hyderabad in South Central Railway; Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus, Bhiwandi Road, Kalyan and Lonavala in Central Railway and Madhupur in Eastern Railway.

The audit also found signs of bacterial contamination in drinking water supplied through taps on railway platforms. Water samples collected from taps at 49 stations across eight zones during 2022-23 and 56 stations across nine zones during 2023-24 showed the presence of total coliform bacteria, including E coli, the CAG report noted.

The audit stressed the need for the Indian Railways to follow prescribed protocols for inspecting water supply systems and conduct comprehensive testing of drinking water quality.

“Only 54 stations (11%) had no shortfalls,” the report notes. Of the 512 stations audited, 325 were non-Amrit Bharat stations. The Amrit Bharat Station Scheme is an ongoing initiative of the Railway Ministry, launched in 2022, to modernise over 1,300 railway stations across the country.

During joint inspection and from the earnings data of Railways, the report further observed that even the stations with very high annual earnings (above ₹ 700 crore) and with heavy passenger footfall (ranging from 1.03 crore to 11.47 crore passengers annually) were not fully compliant with MEA norms. Out of 512 stations audited, 10 such high-revenue, high-footfall stations continued to exhibit deficiencies in MEAs.

Audit observed deficiencies in the provision of drinking water taps at 138 stations, wherein taps were not provided at all in four stations and were short of the prescribed norms in 134 stations.

Norms for the fans vary based on platform width. For platforms having width of 6 mts - 9 mts, one row of fans are to be provided and for platforms having width above 9 mts, two rows of fans are to be provided. However, deficiencies exist in 114 stations30 in the 6 mts - 9 mts category and in 214 stations in the above 9 mts category. For NSG 1 to 4 category stations, the norms prescribed for provision of two water coolers per platform and for NSG 5 category station, one cooler is required to be provided on the main platform. Among 240 NSG 1 to NSG 4 category stations, 128 stations had deficiencies (6 not provided; 122 shortfall). Out of 140 NSG 5 category stations, 23 stations lacked this amenity.

NMC deal puts BoB exposure under lens

They also claimed that the bank failed to carry out adequate anti-money laundering (AML), know-your-customer (KYC) and due diligence checks, contributing to the continuation of the alleged fraud. The Administrators’ findings were upheld by the Court, rejecting BoB’s legal teams’ versions.

“Claims are brought against Bank of Baroda based on allegations that it acted fraudulently and without proper care in contract (under Article 246 of the Civil Code) and in tort (under Articles 282 and 285 of the Civil Code). Secondly, there are the so-called “insolvency claims”, which are made by the Joint Administrators under Section 251 of the ADGM Insolvency Regulations 2022 (the “IR 2022”) in fraudulent trading against Dr Shetty, Mr Manghat and Bank of Baroda, and under Section 252 of the IR 2022 in wrongful trading against Dr Shetty and Mr Manghat. For present purposes, the civil claims are relevant; it is common ground that they are all governed by UAE law. The insolvency claims are governed by ADGM law,” said the judgment of Justice Sir Andrew Smith of Abu Dhabi Global Market Court (ADGMC) of First Instance Commercial and Civil Division, dated March 25, 2025.

The BoB quoted the number of this judgment to the Stock Exchanges without explaining why it paid ₹5,700 crore in public money as a settlement. At the heart of the controversy is the ADGMC litigation arising from NMC Healthcare’s multi-billion-dollar financial collapse. Court records contain allegations concerning BoB’s role in banking transactions connected with the NMC group, including allegations relating to fraudu-

Karnataka Govt to protect livelihood of farmers: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Madikeri (Karnataka)

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday said that his Government has a dual challenge of protecting the livelihood of farmers and also abiding by the law on the issue of releasing Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu.

Invoking rain gods to emerge from the crisis, the CM assured the State’s farmers that their livelihood would be kept in mind while taking decisions on the matter.

He also asserted that the state’s interests will be protected when it comes to the implementation of the Mekedatu project.

“Our dams have not filled yet. We have two big challenges: Releasing water to Tamil Nadu, abiding by the law, and protecting our farmers. Certainly we will protect the interests of our farmers. It is my duty too,” Shivakumar said.

Speaking to reporters after visiting a temple at



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar

Bhagamandala in Kodagu district, he said the Government has a duty to provide water for drinking and agriculture. “Depending on the availability of water at dams, we have to release it to farmers for their crops. Our wish is that there should be good rainfall, crops should flourish, and farmers should have food and livelihood,” he added.

Noting that the Supreme Court has stated there is no objection to constructing any dam within the state, the CM, while speaking on the Mekedatu project said,

the Central Government also made this clear when responding to a Tamil Nadu MP’s query in the Parliament.

He further asserted that he and his government were committed to protecting the interests of the state on this matter.

Mekedatu is a multi-purpose project (drinking water and power) proposed by Karnataka, which involves building a balancing reservoir near Kanakapura in Bengaluru South district. Tamil Nadu opposes the project, fearing

that the state would be affected if it is built.

Reiterating that the construction of the Mekedatu project will not affect Tamil Nadu’s allocated share of 177.25 TMC of water, Shivakumar said, there are separate formulas for water sharing during distress years.

The Cauvery Water Management Authority has issued certain directions. “If there is any crisis, a situation may come where we may have to give the dam keys to the Centre. That should not happen. We have to protect the livelihood of our farmers and also protect and abide by the law. This is very important. To overcome all these, we need blessings of rain gods and all of us should pray for them,” he said.

The Cauvery Water Regulation Committee (CWRC), which met in New Delhi last Tuesday, asked Karnataka to release 12,000 cusecs of water per day starting August 12 for the next 15 days.

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longed overseas litigation? If there was no such pressure, both the Union finance ministry and BoB can remove any ambiguity by explaining the precise process through which the decision was taken and whether any Government authority recommended, suggested or influenced the settlement.

The most important issue, however, is accountability for the original lending decisions. Every large banking loss is the culmination of a chain of decisions. Who sanctioned the loans and credit facilities extended to NMC Healthcare and its associated entities? Which officials and committees approved the exposure? Who monitored repayment? Who reviewed the financial position of the borrower when its liabilities allegedly expanded substantially? Were the bank’s internal audit, risk management, compliance and vigilance mechanisms functioning properly? Were warning signals ignored? If there were deficiencies in due diligence, KYC or anti-money laundering procedures, who was responsible for identifying and correcting them?

Another unresolved issue concerns the reporting of NMC Healthcare and its associated entities as large defaulters. During March-April 2026 series on major bank defaulters by *The Pioneer*, BoB’s large-defaulter list published on March 17 did not appear to include BR Shetty’s NMC Healthcare and its linked entities. Why were these borrowers absent from the list? Were the accounts classified under a different category? Were overseas exposures treated differently for reporting purposes? Were there regulatory or legal reasons for excluding them? If so, BoB should explain those reasons clearly. If not, the bank should clarify how such a significant exposure came to be omitted from a list intended to identify major defaulters.

The bank’s argument that the settlement was made without admission of liability addresses one specific legal issue, but it does not resolve the wider questions surrounding the payment. A settlement does not automatically establish guilt, just as a denial of liability does not by itself explain why thousands of crores of public money were required to close the dispute. The public deserves to know whether the settlement represented the best possible financial outcome after considering all legal and recovery options, or whether the bank could have pursued a more aggressive recovery strategy.

The NMC Healthcare episode is therefore no longer merely a dispute between a foreign corporate group, its promoters, administrators and lenders. For India, it has become a test of accountability within the public banking system. BoB is entrusted with public deposits and substantial public shareholding. Its management therefore has a responsibility to explain not merely what was paid, but why it was paid, who authorized it, what alternatives were examined and what action has been taken against anyone whose decisions may have contributed to the loss.

The role of the Union finance ministry, the Reserve Bank of India and other competent authorities must be examined independently, whether the entire chain of lending, monitoring, recovery, litigation and settlement was handled in accordance with the highest standards of public-sector banking governance. If no wrongdoing or negligence is found, the concerned authorities should say so clearly. If lapses are discovered, those responsible must be identified and held accountable.

Ultimately, the central issue is not whether BoB has legally admitted liability. The central issue is whether the bank obtained the best possible outcome for its shareholders and the Indian public after a prolonged overseas dispute involving thousands of crores. If ₹5,700 crore of public money has effectively closed this chapter, the next chapter must be one of transparency and accountability.

Another important question is who represented BoB in the legal proceedings in Abu Dhabi and before the London courts, and who advised the bank to pursue a settlement through arbitration? Why were the judgments of the lower courts in the UAE not challenged before the higher courts? Could the dispute ultimately have been adjudicated before the International Court of Justice or another appropriate international forum? What were the legal and financial considerations that led BoB and the GoI to settle the matter by reportedly paying a substantial amount of ₹5,700 crore in public funds? At the

same time, BoB has yet to disclose the extent of its losses arising from the large loans extended to NKC Healthcare and its 37 linked entities.

The final question is therefore the simplest, and perhaps the most important: If ₹5,700 crore of public money has been used to close this chapter, who will now open the chapter of accountability?

Vande Mataram row erupts as Shah...

Referring to the Independence Day celebrations held on Saturday, Shah said after 80 years of Independence, Vande Mataram was sung at the Red Fort and all other places where flag hoisting was held. “Thousands of people faced bullets and lathis and were jailed for singing Vande Mataram,” Shah said, referring to the use of the revolutionary slogan during the freedom struggle.

He alleged that during the Independence Day programme at the Congress headquarters, Sonia Gandhi had asked the party president to stop the song midway. “We all saw it on television,” Shah said, adding, “If there is any shame left, you should fold your hands and apologise to Bankim Babu’s immortal spirit and the people.” The home minister alleged that the Congress had forgotten Vande Mataram due to vote-bank politics.

Several other leaders of the ruling BJP also accused Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the singing of the full version of Vande Mataram at the event, a charge that the Congress denied, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the national song and she was only asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge as he was standing for a while.

Congress General Secretary, Jairam Ramesh slammed Shah as someone who insulted BR Ambedkar on the floor of the Rajya Sabha on December 17, 2024, and who belongs to an ideology that did not see fit to unfurl the tricolour at its organisation’s headquarters till January 2002. “A man who insulted Dr Ambedkar on the floor of the Rajya Sabha on Dec 17, 2024. A man who belongs to an ideology that did not see fit to unfurl the *tiranga* at its headquarters till Jan 2002. A man who orchestrated the Delhi Police’s brutalities on peacefully protesting youth. Such a man is now demanding an apology from the Congress to divert attention away from the real issues of the day and away from the colossal failures of his and his Sahib’s,” Ramesh said in a statement.

Congress’s media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra said when lathis rained down for chanting Vande Mataram, it was the Congress that had sounded the bugle of freedom through this song.

Pistol fires at airport check in Varanasi...

Both were taken to New Laxmi Trauma Centre and are now out of danger. Airport operations continued as normal after the situation was quickly handled.

After airport employee Sunil Kumar Singh filed a complaint, police charged Rai under sections 125A and 125B of the IPC for causing hurt by negligence. He could face up to six months in jail or a fine for simple hurt, and up to three years in jail or a fine for grievous hurt. Rai is now being questioned. Authorities also said officials may suggest cancelling Rai’s arms licence, which is valid across India.

The injured screeners explained what happened: one said Rai removed the magazine, checked the pistol, and then pulled the trigger after saying it was unloaded. Another said Rai showed the gun was ‘unloaded’ by pulling the trigger, which caused it to fire. The bullet did not hit anyone directly but bounced and caused the injuries.

BCAS and aviation rules require passengers to inform airline counter staff or security if they have firearms when entering the terminal. They are not allowed to remove, unlock, or handle weapons in general or check-in areas. These steps must happen in a separate strong room.

Officials said Varanasi Airport does not have a dedicated strong room, so inspections take place in less private areas. The Ministry of Civil Aviation said BCAS is checking if the right steps for handling licensed weapons were followed.

Vande Mataram row: Complaint filed against Sonia, Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A complaint has been filed with the Delhi Police seeking registration of an FIR against Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi and Rahul Gandhi over alleged obstruction during the singing of the national song “Vande Mataram” at the Independence Day function at the Congress headquarters here. The complaint, filed by an advocate, was submitted at the IP Estate police station on August 16.

According to the complaint, the Independence Day function was organised at the AICC headquarters on August 15, during which “Vande Mataram” was being sung. It alleges that Sonia Gandhi, who was present at the function, made gestures after the initial portion of the National Song had been sung, which the complainant claimed appeared to indicate an objection to its continuation. The complaint also refers to a video in which Rahul Gandhi is allegedly heard saying, “We are not singing Vande Mataram.”

The complainant has sought an impartial investiga-



tion and appropriate action against both leaders if they are found responsible.

The BJP on Sunday hit out at its top leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge showed “utter disrespect” towards the national song when it was being sung at the party’s Independence Day event, and demanded an apology from them.

Several leaders of the ruling BJP also accused Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the singing of the full version of Vande Mataram at the event, a charge that the Congress denied, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the song. Last month, Parliament passed a bill that makes any insult to the national song a punishable offence.

The ministry said, “Appropriate action will be taken based on the findings.”

Local police, including teams from Phulpur and senior officers such as the DCP Gomti Zone, visited the site and confirmed that Rai had declared the weapon before the accidental firing during pre-boarding checks with CISF and airline staff. There are still questions about whether all Standard Operating Procedures were followed, especially the rule about unloading the magazine near a busy counter area.

Since this happened during a time of heightened security, there are greater concerns about any gaps in the process that allowed a live round to remain in the chamber during inspection.

Investigators are trying to find out exactly what happened and if any mistakes led to the shot being fired. Airport director Puneet Gupta said the passenger had declared the firearm properly and that the shot was fired during inspection. Both injured staff members got medical attention right away, and the situation was quickly brought under control.

Former deputy Speaker of West Bengal found...

Accusing the BJP for harassing the TMC leaders after the elections party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee wrote “his final note raises serious and troubling questions about the sustained smear campaign he said he had endured. The BJP and sections of the media must reflect on the consequences of a politics where allegations are amplified, reputations are put on trial and individuals are condemned in the court of public opinion before the truth is established... his tragic death is not merely heartbreaking ... it should trouble the conscience of everyone who believes that politics and journalism must have boundaries.”

Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said that it should be seen whether he was a victim of threat from the corrupt elements in the TMC.

Bengal Minister Agnimitra Paul too said, “It needs to be seen whether he actually died by suicide or was murdered. Just because a letter has been left behind does not mean it should immediately be called suicide.”

Dhaka presses India on Hasina as PM visit talks...

Bangladesh State Minister for Foreign Affairs, Shama Obaed Islam said on Thursday that Rahman’s proposed visits to India and Japan had not yet been finalised.

She said the timing of any visit would depend on the PM’s schedule and the progress of discussions between the two countries.

“The Government is busy, the Prime Minister is busy,” she told reporters, referring to the Government’s ongoing domestic programmes and upcoming constitutional activities.

Asked whether Rahman would attend the BRICS Summit outreach session or undertake a separate bilateral visit to India, the state minister said there was still sufficient time to take a decision. “A lot can happen in a month,” she said.

Meanwhile, Indian High Commissioner to Bangladesh Dinesh Trivedi on Saturday underscored the importance of closer cooperation and the need to nurture the longstanding ties between the two countries. Speaking at a reception marking India’s 80th Independence Day at the Indian High Commission in Dhaka, Trivedi said Bangladesh and India were strengthening their partnership across several areas, including trade, connectivity, security and healthcare.

“We recognise that it is the people-to-people connection, rooted in shared aspiration and mutual goodwill, that remains the true beating heart of this enduring friendship,” he said.

Trivedi called for continued cooperation to advance shared prosperity and urged both countries to nurture their “exceptional bonds of friendship.” “With the history of the freedom struggle, our bond is deeply entwined,” he said. “On this solid bedrock of shared history, mutual respect, and partnership, our relationship continues to flourish.”

Bangladesh’s latest statement comes as Dhaka and New Delhi continue consultations on high-level engagements. The proposed visit by Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to India remains subject to further discussions and a mutually conducive diplomatic environment.



GRAPEVINE

Tickled pink to be a minister!

After the end of Monsoon Session of Parliament, again rumours on Cabinet reshuffle has resurfaced. Grapevine is on the MPs staying back in Delhi after end of the Session. Along with reshuffle, rumours are abuzz on the formation of a new BJP team. Media, as well as political pundits are working on extra time to Delhi's routine tips. Some say – this time before Diwali or soon after Diwali. Some say before Winter Session. And the buzz is going on creating new-new stories. Grapevine also has it that the older lots in the Council of Ministers are in a tizzy as it is tacit now that Prime Minister Narendra Modi will now tilt more towards accommodation young party MPs in his Council given the current restlessness amongst the Gen Z. In the just concluded Monsoon Session, journalists while exchanging greetings with the younger BJP MPs use to quip, “*Ab To Is Baar Apka To Chance Banega*”.



MEA petrified over embassy funding of media events

It is learnt through sources in the Ministry of External Affairs that a demarche has been issued to all foreign embassies that funding any events related to domestic politics will not be tolerated and that such funding violates several domestic laws. The genesis of this seems to have started with the funding of two news portals joint event in 2025 by the embassies of Norway, Belgium, the Netherlands, Switzerland, Canada, and Ireland. On being intimidated about the antecedents of the said news portals, grapevine has it the Norwegian and Belgian embassies has put the portal under investigation and ceased all funding. However the Irish, Canadian, Dutch and Swiss embassies increased funding. It has come to the attention of the MEA that such funding had been going on and subsequently a formal demarche has been issued that such funding violates India's interpretation of the Vienna convention.



Yogi to woo Laxmi before polls!

As there is a growing resentments within the public over the current students' and Gen-Z led protests across the country, and when elections in nearing in the crucial Uttar Pradesh, grapevine has it that the bureaucracy in the State have been asked to study on the women and youth centric projects which could have grant of financial benefits similar to the ones in Madhya Pradesh, polls manifestos of Delhi, West Bengal which is believed to do wonders for the BJP. Uttar Pradesh Government is likely to woo Ladlis with Laxmi Yojna, etc. It was first started in Madhya Pradesh by the Shivraj Singh Chouhan Government to provide monthly sustenance to women and then dicked in Delhi and Bengal. Since UP is a crucial state in terms of a larger number of Lok Sabha MPs, party and bureaucracy sources said the State Government is considering a similar Yojana before the Vidhan Sabha elections. At this point, the Samajwadi Party-led opposition that altered the contours of the BJP in the 2024 General Election has cornered the Yogi Government.



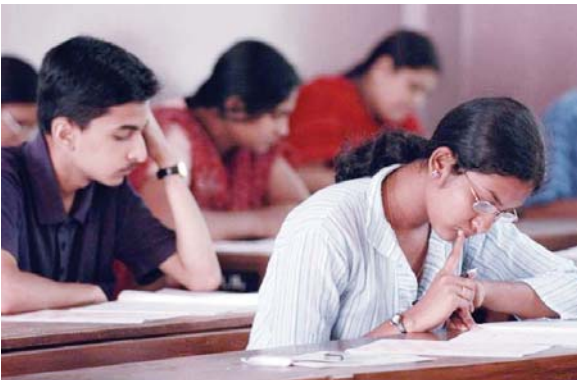
NTA announces retest for three papers of UGC-NET after errors

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) on Sunday announced the retest for three papers of the UGC-NET June 2026 examination— English, Commerce and Sociology — following complaints about several errors in these papers.

The English paper will be held on September 9 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift 1, while the Commerce paper will be conducted the same day from 3 pm to 6 pm in Shift 2. The Sociology paper will be held on September 10 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift 1.

The NTA conducted the UGC-NET June 2026 examination from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects for the award of Junior Research



Fellowship (JRF), eligibility for assistant professor, and admission to PhD programmes.

In a public notice, the NTA said it had received several complaints about multiple errors in these papers of the three subjects and constituted a

committee to look into these issues.

The committee found that the three papers had many factual, typographical, and translation errors including misspelt names of prominent scholars, garbled book titles, errors in the stem wording of questions, gram-

matical errors, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation mistakes, and non-standard coined terms for established concepts, as well as repetition of a significant number of questions previously administered, the agency said.

The panel recommended that in the interest of holding a fair and error-free examination, these three papers should be re-conducted, it added.

“It has therefore been concluded by NTA that papers carrying such defects do not meet the standards of fairness and error-free examination, and defects of this extent cannot be cured merely by dropping questions after the challenge process,” the agency said.

West Bengal starts Ayushman Bharat

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

Bengal Government on Sunday officially launched the Aushmaan Bharat health insurance scheme marking August 16 as the Aushmaan Bharat Day replacing the Khela Hobe Diwas coined by the previous Trinamool Congress Government.

The scheme was launched at the iconic Netaji Indoor Stadium in Kolkata by Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari. Among others present in the programme were Union Minister Sukanta Majumdar, Bengal Health Minister Saradwat Mukherjee. Hence forward August 16 would be organized as Ayushmaan Day the Chief Minister said adding all citizens aged 70 and above would qualify automatically regardless of income. He also assured that no eligible resident will be left out, with remaining portions of the population getting covered by a parallel State insurance scheme.

While the Aysuhmaan Bharat scheme would take



within its ambit 3.39 crore people the remaining population will be covered by the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Bima Yojana., Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari said. The beneficiaries of Ayushman Bharat will be able to access about 14,000 hospitals throughout India and within Bengal the scheme will be available in 1930 hospitals including 1303 private facilities, Health Minister Saradwath Mukherjee said. The details of the Ayushmaan Bharat beneficiaries will be available in the Ayushmaan Bharat portal and the scheme will offer cashless coverage of up to ₹5 lakh per year to its recipients who will receive coverage from three days before hospitalisation until 15 days after discharge.

SIR led to record turnout in Bihar Assembly polls: CEC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar on Sunday asserted that the “successful” Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Bihar last year had led to a significant rise in voter turnout in the assembly polls that followed.

Speaking to reporters at Patna airport, the CEC, who is on a two-day tour of the state, said the voting percentage in the 2025 Bihar assembly polls was higher than turnouts witnessed in advanced countries such as the US, the UK and France.

“Bihar is the land where Vaishali, the cradle of democracy, is situated. We take pride in the fact that the SIR was conducted here successfully for the first time,” Kumar said.

The CEC pointed out that following the mammoth exercise, conducted over a three-month period during which around 70 lakh names were knocked off the electoral rolls, a sharp rise was seen in the voter turnout when assembly polls which were held soon afterwards. “As you all know, men and



women came out in large numbers to vote and the turnout broke all records in the state. It may be noted that the voter turnout in Bihar assembly polls was higher than what has been seen, over the years, in major democracies like the US, the UK, France, Spain and Japan,” the CEC added.

The assembly polls held in November last year registered a voter turnout of 67.25 per cent, which, according to the Election Commission, was the highest for the state since Independence.

According to officials, the CEC is scheduled to interact with around 500 booth-level officers (BLOs) at Nalanda University in Rajgir on

NLSIU students, alumni oppose CJI Kant attending convocation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Students and Alumni of the National Law School of India University (NLSIU) here have opposed CJI Surya Kant and Bar Council of India Chairman Manan Kumar Mishra attending the upcoming convocation of the varsity.

In a statement dated August 15, the students and alumni condemned the now-withdrawn BCI order to halt the enrolment of students of NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, and expressed their solidarity with the students at NALSAR, who they said have shown exemplary courage and moral conviction in speaking truth to power.

“We are aware that the BCI has closed all proceedings against NALSAR. However, the fact that such unconstitutional and illegal “proceedings”



can be initiated by a statutory body against students and faculty members of a public university in the first place does not alter the nature or the larger impact of such actions or dilute the responsibility of the Chairman and the BCI,” the statement signed by 165 graduating students of the Class of 2026, 409 current students and 128 alumni.

They claimed that even after the recall of the ban on enrolment and the inquiry order, the BCI has acknowledged the “arbitrary” and “illegal nature” of its actions.

TN ministers demanding kickbacks on tenders, have audio proof, claims Annamalai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Former BJP leader K Annamalai on Sunday alleged that some Tamil Nadu ministers had begun demanding kickbacks in Government tenders, claiming to have audio recordings to substantiate the charge.

Addressing an environmental awareness gathering organised by the outfit in Chennai, Annamalai said that while Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay was opposed to corruption, some of his Cabinet colleagues had started demanding kickbacks from contractors. “It is true that the CM is against corruption, and we see that. They did not take kickbacks in major tenders earlier, but some ministers have started demanding them now,” Annamalai alleged.

Claiming to have audio evidence of the alleged



Former BJP leader K Annamalai

demands, he said, “Some ministers are saying they came after giving money for votes, so give two per cent, give three per cent, give four per cent.”

Urging the CM to rein in his Cabinet before the issue escalated, Annamalai said his organisation would formally raise the matter after the Government had completed its initial period in

office. “You (Vijay) stated in your Independence Day address that corruption would be eradicated in our lifetime. Tighten the reins on ministers and officials with regular weekend review meetings, because if the reins are loosened, the administration will drift,” he added.

Annamalai, who recently launched We The Leaders, a

grassroots leadership movement, said it was not seeking to destabilise the newly elected Government and would give it time to function.

“Out of 234 MLAs, 154 members have entered the Assembly for the first time following the 2026 elections. We say everywhere: Give them one year. Let them do their work. If they do not perform properly, we will be the first to point it out,” he said.

During his address, Annamalai reiterated his opposition to Karnataka's proposed Mekedatu reservoir project on the Cauvery river.

He urged the Centre to address recurring NEET question paper leaks and called on the state Government to use budgetary savings for rural water rejuvenation, Government school infrastructure and development.

Visakhapatnam airport ends scheduled commercial operations ahead of Bhogapuram opening

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Visakhapatnam

Visakhapatnam Airport ended its scheduled commercial flight operations ahead of the opening of Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram on Monday.

The last scheduled commercial flight from Visakhapatnam Airport (INS Dega) will be IndiGo flight 6E 2018 to Delhi, scheduled to depart at 10.45 pm on Sunday.

“Visakhapatnam Airport has reached an important milestone with the conclusion of its scheduled commercial operations, and we sincerely acknowledge the contribution of every employee, stakeholder and partner who supported the airport's operations and passenger services over the years,” Visakhapatnam Airport Director N Purushottam said in a press release.



As notified by the Ministry of Civil Aviation, scheduled commercial operations at the Visakhapatnam Civil Enclave will cease with the commencement of operations at Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram at 12.01 am on August 17.

The IATA airport code ‘VTZ’ will be transferred from Visakhapatnam Airport to the new airport at

Bhogapuram with effect from August 17.

Non-scheduled commercial operations, however, may continue at the Civil Enclave at Visakhapatnam Airport, the press release said.

Purushottam said Visakhapatnam Airport had played a key role in connecting the city and Andhra Pradesh with major domestic destinations and had served

passengers, businesses, tourists and the regional economy for several decades.

Over the years, the airport saw growth in passenger traffic and infrastructure, including terminal expansion, better aircraft parking, security and passenger facilities, DigiYatra services, accessibility measures and sustainability initiatives.

The Airports Authority of India expressed gratitude to the Central Industrial Security Force, airlines, ground-handling agencies, regulatory authorities, concessionaires and other service partners for their contribution to the airport's safe, secure and efficient functioning, it said.

The AAI acknowledged the continued support of the Indian Navy in facilitating civil aviation operations at the Civil Enclave, saying its coordination would remain important as non-scheduled commercial operations continue.

Stay away from drugs, all forms of substance abuse: VP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Sunday urged students to stay away from drugs and all forms of substance abuse, and called upon them to choose “discipline over distraction, purpose over temptation, and excellence over easy shortcuts.”

Expressing deep anguish over the recent murder of a student in Tamil Nadu for sharing information regarding drug trafficking, the Vice President said the tragic incident felt like losing a member of his own family.

“I urge all of you (students) to always stay away

from the menace of drugs and all forms of substances that abuse. We should not get controlled by an external force rather our mind should get controlled by ourselves... We must say no to drugs,” he said.

In his address at the 22nd convocation at SRM Institute of Science and Technology near here, he highlighted the expansion of higher education in the country since 2014.

Stating that 16 IIITs, eight Central Universities, eight IIMs, seven IITs, two IISERs, one NIT and 12 AIIMS have been established during this period, he said, “Bharat today has more than 1,425 universities, 54,000 colleges



Vice President CP Radhakrishnan during the 22nd Convocation of SRM Institute of Science and Technology (SRMIST) at Kattankulathur, Chengalpattu near Chennai

and 16,850 standalone institutions.”

Highlighting that a substantial increase in women's enrolment in higher education, from 1.57 crore in 2014-15 to 2.24 crore in 2023-24, an increase of 42.2 per cent, he said the increasing number of women receiving degrees and medals at convocation ceremonies was a welcome development.

Recalling India's response to the Covid-19 pandemic, the Vice President said that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the country provided coronavirus vaccines to more than 100 countries.

Five held in murder of CJP worker's father

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

The police on Sunday arrested five people on charges of beating to death the father of a Cockroach Janata Party volunteer in Bankura district. The incident took place on Friday and the victim died on Saturday.

Sk Mafik the father of CJP volunteer Shaik Abdul Hafeez was reportedly attacked by some alleged supporters of the BJP for visiting a local Government school to inspect as per the “school theek karo (repair the school)” programme

earlier organised by the CJP leadership.

“They came in search of me and as they could not find me they beat up my father... he received head injuries and died... they had earlier asked me to upload a video apologising for my act of visiting the school... they also asked me to acknowledge that I had gone to that school at the behest of outside CJP leaders,” Hafeez said. While the national CJP leadership demanded impartial investigation into the matter Bengal Chief Minister denied role of his party.

Nation pays tribute to Atal Bihari Vajpayee on 8th death anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The nation paid homage to former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee on the occasion of his death anniversary on Sunday. The BJP stalwart breathed his last on this day in 2018. Vajpayee served as the Prime Minister on three occasions. The first BJP leader to become prime minister, Vajpayee was born on December 25, 1924, in Gwalior.

His first term as the Prime Minister was for only 13 days in 1996. He served his second term for a period of eleven months from 1998 to 1999 and then a full term from 1999 to 2004. He was awarded India's highest civilian honour — Bharat Ratna — in 2015. Dignitaries will pay floral tributes to the former Prime Minister at his memorial Sadaiv Atal, here.

President Droupadi Murmu, Vice President CP Radhakrishnan, and Prime Minister Narendra Modi paid floral tributes to Vajpayee at his memorial. Former President Ram Nath Kovind, Deputy Chairman of Rajya Sabha Harivansh, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, Union Minister Rajnath Singh, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, and BJP National President Nitin Nabin were also present on the occasion.

Radhakrishnan, in a social



President Droupadi Murmu along with VP CP Radhakrishnan, PM Narendra Modi, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and BJP National President Nitin Nabin during former prime minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's death anniversary at his memorial 'Sadaiv Atal' in New Delhi PTI

media post, said that his enduring legacy will always remain a source of inspiration for the nation. He added that his commitment to nation-building, inclusive leadership and national pride continues to inspire generations.

Sharing a social media post, Prime Minister Modi called Vajpayee an extraordinary statesman blessed with remarkable vision, who dedicated his life to the service of the nation. He added that the words and efforts of the former Prime Minister inspired generations and his leadership strengthened the nation. He also said Vajpayee's focus on good governance and public welfare will always continue

to guide countrymen.

In his tributes, Speaker Om Birla noted in a social media post that Vajpayee was such a titan of Indian politics whose personality embodied a unique confluence of patriotism, democratic values, sensitivity, and extraordinary oratory.

He added that over a parliamentary career spanning more than five decades, he was elected to the Lok Sabha ten times and to the Rajya Sabha twice. Birla said that the former Prime Minister will always be remembered as a fiery parliamentarian, a powerful orator, an accomplished journalist, and a sensitive poet.

Union Home Minister Amit

Shah unveiled a statue of Vajpayee in the Chittorgarh district of Rajasthan. He highlighted that the former prime minister's value-based politics brought the vision of 'Antyodaya' and good governance to the ground for the first time. He described Vajpayee as a patriotic politician who devoted every moment of his life to the nation.

"On one hand, he made the entire world aware of India's strength through nuclear tests and the Kargil War, while on the other hand, his value-based politics brought the vision of Antyodaya and good governance to the ground for the first time," Shah said.

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh also visited Vajpayee's memorial and said that under his leadership, India achieved new heights in economic and social development.

"His contribution to India's progress will always be remembered. His personality, ideals and unwavering commitment to serving the nation will always remain a source of inspiration for us," he said.

BJP President Nabin said, "A towering statesman and true visionary, Atal Ji's life was dedicated to national service, integrity, and good governance. His ideals will forever guide our path towards nation-building," he said.

PM thanks global partners, neighbours for 80th I-Day greetings

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday thanked his Israeli counterpart Benjamin Netanyahu for his greetings on India's 80th Independence Day, and hoped the bilateral special strategic partnership grows even stronger, unlocking new opportunities and forging deeper people-to-people connections.

Modi also conveyed his gratitude to French President Emmanuel Macron, Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah and Bhutan Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay among others for their wishes on India's Independence Day.

In his message, Netanyahu congratulated India and "my dear friend" Prime Minister Modi on the country's 80th Independence Day.

The Israeli prime minister noted that India and Israel achieved independence one year apart and both the countries are two ancient nations that seize the future together to bring a better life for the people of the two countries.

"Our innovation and friendship are boundless. The best is yet to come!" he said. Thanking Prime Minister Netanyahu for his



warm wishes, Modi hoped that the "India-Israel Special Strategic Partnership grow even stronger, unlocking new opportunities and forging deeper people-to-people connections between our nations."

Israeli President Isaac Herzog also greeted President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Modi on the occasion of Independence Day.

"I hope that we will continue to strengthen this beautiful friendship between Israel and India," he said.

Modi said India deeply values its friendship with Israel. "We remain committed to further strengthening our Strategic Partnership for the benefit of our people," he said.

The prime minister also thanked French President Macron for his warm wishes.

Nation Focus

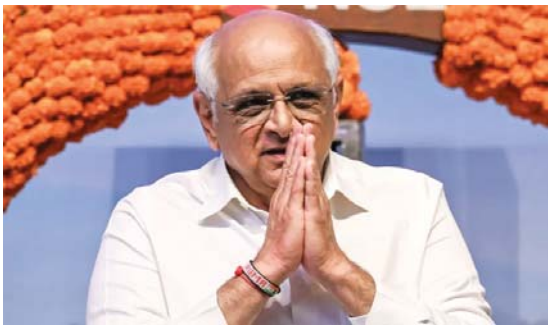


MEHBOOBA MUFTI VISITS FLOOD-AFFECTED RAJOURI

Peoples Democratic Party (PDP) president Mehbooba Mufti on Sunday visited several flood-affected areas of Jammu and Kashmir's Rajouri district to assess the ground situation, urging the Government to provide relief to the affected families.

Mehbooba expressed concern over the extensive damage to residential houses, agricultural land, business establishments and water supply infrastructure, besides the loss of lives in the natural calamity.

At least 11 people were killed and several others went missing when torrential rains on July 19 triggered landslides and flash floods in the twin border districts of Poonch and Rajouri. Interacting with affected families, she was informed that many victims were yet to receive adequate Government assistance and were facing difficulties in rebuilding their homes and restoring their livelihoods. (PTI)



GUJARAT CM PATEL IN US, CANADA TO WOO INVESTORS

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel on Sunday embarked on an official visit to the United States and Canada to promote the Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2027 and invite global investors to participate in the state's growth story. Patel will be in the two countries from August 17 to 24 and is scheduled to hold meetings with business leaders, industry representatives and potential investors. Roadshows and business-to-business interactions are also planned as part of the overseas outreach programme.

The visit is aimed at showcasing Gujarat's industrial strengths, investment opportunities and business-friendly ecosystem to international stakeholders.

The state Government is also seeking to deepen international partnerships and facilitate greater collaboration between global business groups and companies based in Gujarat. (PNS)

IMD sounds red alert: As Odisha braces for more heavy rain, over 2.37 lakh evacuated

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The Odisha Government on Sunday sounded a high alert across the state after the IMD forecast extremely heavy rainfall in some areas following the formation of a fresh low-pressure area over the Bay of Bengal. The state has evacuated over 2.37 lakh people to safety as heavy rain continued for the second day, adding to the plight of people in flood-hit northern districts, an offi-

cial said. Chief Secretary Anu Garg, who reviewed the situation following the IMD forecast, said the leaves of all Government employees had been cancelled and those on leave were asked to report for duty immediately.

"We have asked the district collectors to remain on high alert as the IMD forecast very heavy rain for three days from August 16 to 18," Garg told reporters. She said fresh flooding had affected 5.15 lakh people in 947 villages under



331 gram panchayats across 49 blocks and five urban areas.

The state has so far evacuated 2.37 lakh people and sheltered them in 293 relief camps, she said. Garg said three senior IAS officers had been sent to the worst-hit districts of Balasore, Bhadrak and Jajpur to coordinate with the district administrations and monitor relief and rescue operations. Additional chief engineers of the Water Resources Department have also been deployed to

oversee the safety of embankments and carry out immediate repairs in case of breaches, she said.

Around 90 rescue teams, including 36 ODRF, seven NDRF and 47 Fire Services teams, have been deployed in vulnerable areas, Garg said.

Teams from the health, water resources, housing and urban development, and fisheries and animal resources departments have also been deployed in the affected areas, she said.

10 Rajya Sabha MPs elected to AIIMS and other statutory bodies unopposed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ten members of the Rajya Sabha have been elected to various statutory bodies including AIIMS institutes across the country, as the number of candidates equalled the vacancies.

While Rajya Sabha MP Gulam Ali has been elected to be a member of the AIIMS, Awantipora; Ashok Kumar Mittal has been elected as a member of AIIMS, Bathinda; and Rajneesh Kumar Agrawal as a member of AIIMS, Bhopal.

AGP MP from Assam Birendra Prasad Baishya was elected as a member of AIIMS, Guwahati; BJP MP from Jammu and Kashmir Sat Paul Sharma was elected as a member of AIIMS, Vijaypur; I S Inbadurai as member of AIIMS, Madurai; and Madan Rathore as a member of AIIMS, Jodhpur.

Lahar Singh Siroya has also



been elected as a member of the Central Silk Board, BJP MP from Himachal Pradesh Sikander Kumar has been elected as member of the Council of the National Institutes of Food Technology, Entrepreneurship and Management and BJP MP from Haryana Rekha Sharma was elected as a member of the National Assisted Reproductive Technology and Surrogacy Board.

The members were elected as there were equal number

of vacancies as the number of candidates nominated for elections to the statutory bodies, a notification by Rajya Sabha secretariat said.

In another notification, the RS Secretariat said the number of candidates being equal to the number of members to be elected to the Committee on Public Accounts and Committee on Public Undertakings, the following members were declared duly elected to these Committees.

BJP MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray and DMK MP Tiruchi Siva were elected as members of the Committee on Public Accounts and Mohammed Nadimul Haque was elected as a member of the Committee on Public Undertakings.

With the number of candidates being equal to the number of members to be elected to the Committee on Welfare of Other Backward Classes, the following members were declared duly elected to be the members of the committee for a term of one year beginning from the date of the first sitting of the committee.

The members elected to the OBC Committee are Masthan Rao Yadav Beedha, Subhasish Khuntia, Amar Pal Maurya, Mayankkumar Nayak, AA Rahim, KRN Rajeshkumar, Kalpana Saini, Paka Venkata Satyanarayana, Ashok Singh and Bhim Singh.

Army dog Tyson honoured with Mention-in-Despatches for bravery in Jammu and Kashmir operation

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Jammu

Tyson, the youngest member of the Indian Army's Dog Squad attached to 2 Para Special Forces, has been honoured during the Independence Day 2026 celebrations for showing "bravery and extraordinary courage" during a counter-insurgency operation on February 22, 2026, in Kishtwar.

The name of Tyson, a German Shepherd of the Remount Veterinary Corps, appeared among 89 Mention-in-Despatches (MiD) approved by President Droupadi Murmu on the occasion of Independence Day celebrations.

Tyson was part of the Indian Army's crack team, entrusted with the responsibility to neutralise the terrorists hiding inside a mud house hideout in the Passerkut area of Chhatroo,



Kishtwar.

Displaying raw courage, the Army's sniffer dog, equipped with a K9 surveillance camera system, led from the front even after suffering a bullet injury in his leg. His presence close to the mud house hideout helped the crack team locate the presence of terrorists during the fierce gunfight.

Tyson's remarkable bravery stood out during the anti terrorist operation

combat zone. "Tyson displayed extraordinary courage by taking the first bullet while leading the entry into the terrorists' hideout.

Undeterred by his injuries, he pressed forward and launched a fierce assault, compelling the terrorists to open fire and thereby confirming their presence.

His fearless action enabled troops of White Knight Corps, J&K police and CRPF to precisely engage and neutralise three Pakistan-sponsored terrorists," Army had said in a post on X.

Tyson is part of the elite squad of Army assault dogs, which are trained like soldiers for high-risk operations.

They are used in situations where a human soldier may be exposed to immediate danger, locating hidden terrorists, detecting threats and helping troops establish the enemy's position.

Jitendra Singh calls for making preventive healthcare, diabetes prevention national priority

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science & Technology and Earth Sciences, Dr Jitendra Singh, who is also a Professor of Medicine and Diabetologist, has called for making preventive healthcare and prevention of diabetes a national priority. He also stressed that the growing burden of diabetes in rural India requires a community-led, technology-enabled and data-driven response.

Addressing the inauguration of the RSSDI 'Diabetes Rural Outreach Digital Portal' and launch of VISHWAS, the Diabetes Awareness Video Library, the minister said with more than 70 per cent of India's population below the age of 40, protecting the health and productive poten-



Union Minister of State (Independent Charge) for Science and Technology Jitendra Singh (second from right) launches the book 'Rheumatology Essentials', written by Professor Anand N Malaviya (second from left), Founder HoD of Rheumatology at AIIMS New Delhi, during a function in New Delhi on Sunday PTI

tial of the country's young population is essential to the vision of India@2047.

The programme organised by the Research Society for the Study of Diabetes in India (RSSDI) on Independence Day, brought together leading

experts and stakeholders from the diabetes and healthcare ecosystem.

Dr Anuj Maheshwari, President, National RSSDI; Dr Rakesh Parikh, Secretary General, National RSSDI; Dr Banshi Saboo, Chair, IDF

South-East Asia; and Rizwan Koita, Chairman, NABH, were among the prominent participants. The RSSDI Rural Outreach Programme and VISHWAS are aimed at taking diabetes awareness, screening, treatment, follow-up and digital health resources closer to communities.

Singh said India has made remarkable progress in healthcare, scientific research and digital innovation, and the next important step is to ensure that these advances reach every citizen, particularly people living in rural and underserved communities.

He said rural India is no longer untouched by the diabetes epidemic and that early detection, timely intervention, lifestyle modification and sustained follow-up are essential to reduce the burden of the disease and its complications.

Describing the RSSDI Rural

Outreach Programme as an example of how professional medical societies can complement national health efforts, the Minister said that adopting villages and creating a structured model for awareness, screening, treatment and long-term follow-up can bring specialist expertise closer to communities that need it most. The programme has already reached around 30 villages across several States, with further expansion planned in the coming years.

Singh said the newly inaugurated digital data portal marks an important milestone in strengthening community healthcare through systematic documentation. A standardised digital platform can enable continuity of patient care, monitoring of outcomes and generation of valuable evidence for future public health strategies.

Army Chief General on 3-day Nepal visit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth on Sunday left for Nepal on Sunday for an official visit from August 17 to 19. The visit aims to further strengthen the close defence cooperation and military-to-military ties between India and Nepal, the defence ministry said here on Sunday.

Giving details about his schedule, it said the Army Chief will lay a wreath at the Army Pavilion, Tundikhel and receive a Guard of Honour at the Nepali Army Headquarters.

He will interact with the Chief of the Army Staff, Nepali Army and will be briefed by the Director General, Military Operations, Nepali Army on issues of mutual interest.

Thereafter, General Seth will attend the Investiture



Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth

Ceremony at Rashtapati Bhawan, where, in keeping with the unique tradition between the Indian and Nepali Armies, he will be conferred the Honorary Rank of General of the Nepali Army by Nepal President Ram Chandra Paudel.

On August 18, General Seth will address the student officers of the Army Command and Staff Course at Shivapuri and interact with instructors and foreign student officers.

He will also be interacting with senior Dignitaries of Nepal on issues of mutual interest. On August 19, General Dhiraj Seth will attend an Ex-Servicemen Rally at Pokhara, felicitate Veer Naris and Gallantry Awardees and interact with Indian Army Veterans.

He will return to India the same day. India and Nepal are two nations with shared historical, social and cultural linkages which remain unparalleled in the world.

Terms fondly referred to as the 'Roti Beti Ka Rishta', the Janakpur-Ayodhya and the Lumbini-Bodhgaya connect make our nations natural partners with symbiotic relations. The partnership between India and Nepal is defined by our democratic principles and shared interest in ensuring regional peace and stability.

Only those who support Maoists, separatists are *dimagi* Naxals: Rijiju

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi's '*dimagi* Naxal' remark in his Independence Day speech sparked a war of words between the Opposition and the BJP, Union Minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday said the PM was not referring to opposition leaders but only to those who support Maoists and separatists and reject the Indian Constitution.

Addressing the nation on the 80th Independence Day, Prime Minister Modi on Saturday warned the country about '*dimagi* Naxals' who have allegedly entrenched themselves in the system and continue to pose a threat to society by manipulating policies. He cautioned that "armed Naxals may have gone, but *dimagi* (intellectual) Naxals are lurking around" and called for "identifying and isolating" them.

Opposition leaders decried it as an attempt to stigmatise dissent and those who question the Government.

In a post on X, Union



Parliamentary Affairs Minister Rijiju said, "PM Narendra Modi ji didn't say opposition leaders as *Dimagi* Naxals."

"Only following are *Dimagi* Naxals: 1. Who support Maoists and reject the Indian Constitution. 2. Who stand with separatists & support Article 370.

"4. Who want to cut chicken neck to separate North-East from India (sic)," he said in veiled reference to student activist Sarjeel Imam, who is in judicial custody in connection with a case under the anti-terror UAPA law.

Imam was arrested on August 25, 2020, and booked

under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for being one of the "master-minds" of the February 2020 riots in northeast Delhi that left 53 people dead and over 700 injured.

Congress Rajya Sabha MP Pawan Khara took a jibe at Rijiju with a post on X: "Brother Kiren Rijiju, get your counting right first, then we'll answer. After 1 and 2 comes 3, not 4."

"Entire Political Science's kamaal (The marvel of entire political science)," Jairam Ramesh said, responding to Khara's comments

Earlier, senior Congress leader P Chidambaram

posted on X, "I am proud to be a *dimagi* naxal".

BJP MP Nishikant Dubey posted an old video of former home minister Chidambaram where he can be purportedly heard pitching against "acquiring" nuclear weapons and inducting them into Indian armed forces until there is a "full and proper debate" in the country and in Parliament about its need.

"Looking at the state of the world today, tell me if this statement by Chidambaram, a leader of Sonia Gandhi-led Congress, is the statement of a '*dimagi* naxal' or not?" Dubey said on X.

In a post on X, BJP national general secretary (organisation) B L Santhosh also slammed Chidambaram, saying, "No surprise. He was the PMC (Project Management Consultant) of Saffron Terrorism — Bhagwat Atankwad project of UPA".

BJP's IT department head Amit Malviya said that "'*Dimagi* Naxals' has hit them right where it hurts. It is such a delight to see them writhing like snakes in a sandpit".

LG Manoj Sinha assures Kashmiri Pandit employees, says peace will be maintained

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Reaching out to the Kashmiri Pandit employees engaged under the Prime Minister's Package, Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha on Sunday said there is no need for people to worry over attempts to disturb peace in the Union Territory, asserting that the administration and security forces are fully committed to maintaining peace.

In his first interaction with the members of the Kashmiri Pandit community in Jammu after a Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT) linked terrorist outfit issued a threatening letter warning of attacks on these employees, LG Sinha clearly stated that anyone who attempts to disrupt peace will not be allowed to succeed.

He emphasised that the administration, police, and security forces are fully dedicated to ensuring a peaceful environment.

He acknowledged that such efforts are being made but asserted that there is no need for people to panic.



"Attempts are being made to disturb the atmosphere again. There is no need to worry. The necessary concerns are being addressed, and this has not started today; such efforts have been underway for some time," Sinha said at the annual-day function of the Kashmiri Pandit Volunteers (KPV) here.

"There are also people who spread rumours. I assure you that the administration and security forces are fully committed to maintaining peace. Anyone who

attempts to disrupt the prevailing peace will not be allowed to succeed in their designs," he said.

"There are many challenges, including the one you mentioned. But I believe there are even bigger challenges that we have to address," the LG said.

He said the biggest challenge in the past was the perception that no one would be willing to carry the national flag in Jammu and Kashmir. "But you have seen today that there are so many shoulders, and such strong

shoulders, ready to carry the tricolour. What you have witnessed today is a powerful example of that change," Sinha said. In response to a KP leader's demand for enhanced relief, the LG said the Government is making continuous efforts to resolve issues.

"I would like to say, with a full sense of responsibility, that efforts have been made to find a solution and these efforts are continuing.

"While some issues can be resolved, others cannot be addressed immediately. Nevertheless, continuous efforts are being made to resolve all matters that can be addressed at the earliest," he said.

The remarks came after KPV founder Vikram Kaul, in his address, urged the Government and the LG not to restore statehood to Jammu and Kashmir, citing security concerns and the challenges facing the Union Territory, to enhance monthly relief and ensure long-term security to KP employees in the valley in the wake of terror attacks.

CBI nabs railway engineer red-handed in Vijayawada over ₹15 lakh bribe

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) arrested a senior railway official and a private individual on Sunday after catching the engineer accepting a ₹15 lakh bribe.

The accused, a Senior Section Engineer with the Chief Signal and Telecommunications Engineer (CSTE) Projects office at South Central Railway in Vijayawada, was caught taking cash from a private person.

The money was reportedly a reward for helping approve and release a large bonus claim to a joint venture company connected to the private individual's father.

The CBI said it registered the case earlier on Sunday against the Senior Section

Engineer, four private company representatives, and some unidentified public servants and private individuals. The agency received information that officials in the CSTE Projects wing had changed dates in official records related to a bonus claim. The joint venture of two private companies had received a contract worth ₹179.50 crore from South Central Railway for Automatic Block Signalling work.

The firm later claimed a bonus of about ₹7 crore for finishing the project early.

Investigators found that railway officials may have helped by changing the dates on the file to approve the claim. The CBI learned that the Managing Director (MD) of one of the private companies told the Senior Section



Engineer that his son would deliver the bribe while travelling from Visakhapatnam to Vijayawada on August 16. Acting on this tip, CBI teams set up a trap.

The engineer was caught accepting ₹15 lakh in cash, and the full amount was

recovered on the spot. Both the Senior Section Engineer and the private person were taken into custody that day.

Immediately after the arrests, CBI teams searched the homes and offices of the accused and related people in Visakhapatnam,

Vijayawada, Pithapuram, and Hyderabad. They are looking for more documents, digital evidence, and any other proceeds from the alleged corruption.

CBI officials said the investigation is ongoing and more arrests may happen as they look into the larger conspiracy. Of alleged corruption in railway project clearances. Officials pointed out that large infrastructure contracts, particularly those involving time-bound bonuses, remain vulnerable to record manipulation and demands for illegal gratification.

The recovery of the exact amount and the documented communication between the private company and the railway official are expected to be key evidence in the prosecution's case.

Investigators are also checking if other officials in the CSTE Projects office were involved in changing the bonus file.

For South Central Railway, this incident raises important questions about how high-value claims are checked internally. The project itself is a critical safety and capacity-enhancement work on the busy network.

Any delay or irregularity in its financial closure can have wider operational implications.

As the accused face court proceedings on Monday, the CBI has made it clear that the net is still being cast wider. Searches across four cities suggest the agency is looking for money trails, additional beneficiaries and possible systemic collusion.

Torrential rain disrupts normal life in Himachal Pradesh; 109 roads blocked



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shimla

Torrential rain led to the closure of 109 roads across Himachal Pradesh on Sunday, with the local meteorological office issuing an orange alert for heavy to very heavy rain at isolated places in four districts on August 17 and 18.

The orange alert has been issued across Bilaspur, Chamba, Kangra and Mandi districts for Monday, and in Una, Chamba and Kangra districts for Tuesday, the Met office said. Two families at Thakurdwara near Palampur in Kangra district had a narrow escape on Sunday morning after a tree fell on their building, officials said.

The building, adjacent shops and parked vehicles were damaged in the tree collapse, leading to a brief traffic congestion on the Palampur-Hamirpur highway, they said.

Moderate to heavy rain lashed parts of Kangra dis-

trict since Saturday evening. Dharamshala recorded 126.3 mm of rainfall in the past 24 hours, followed by Palampur at 55 mm and Kangra at 34.6 mm, Met office data showed.

According to the State Emergency Operations Centre, 43 roads were closed in Mandi, 33 in Kullu, eight in Sirmour, seven in Shimla, six each in Chamba and Kangra, four in Una and two in Lahaul-Spiti.

As many as 216 water supply lines and seven power transformers were also damaged in the rain, the officials said.

Since the onset of monsoon on June 30, 79 people have died in rain-related incidents in the state, including 14 in landslides and one in a flash flood. The state has suffered estimated losses of Rs 973 crore so far, the officials said.

Himachal Pradesh has received 128.3 mm of rainfall against a normal of 156.5 mm from August 1-16, a deficit of 18 per cent, they said.

Harsimrat Badal urges Shah for NIA probe into attacks on Sukhbir Badal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

SAD MP Harsimrat Kaur Badal on Sunday wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah, seeking a National Investigation Agency (NIA) probe into the August 13 attack on party president Sukhbir Singh Badal and an assassination attempt on him at the Golden Temple in December 2024. Harsimrat Kaur, who is wife of Sukhbir Badal, described the August 13 incident in Maharashtra's Nanded as a "dastardly and heinous assassination bid".

The two assassination attempts had "several disturbing parallels" and raised serious questions about whether they were connect-



ed and whether there was a "larger conspiracy" behind them, the former Union minister said in her letter to Shah.

"I write with a mix of personal pain and profound concern for our society, our state of Punjab and our country, particularly over the

manner in which violence is being normalised and even justified by persons holding positions of power in Punjab, apparently as a means of pursuing political battles," she wrote.

Sukhbir Badal sustained injuries to his right hand in a 'kirpan' (ceremonial dagger) attack by a member of the Nihang order inside a gurdwara on the outskirts of Maharashtra's Nanded town on Thursday. The attacker was later arrested.

Referring to the attack, Harsimrat Kaur said Sukhbir Badal, accompanied by her and their children, was coming out after paying obeisance at the Guru Ghar when an assailant attacked him with a sword.

The consequences could have been "fatal" had an alert security personnel not intervened and risked his own life to prevent the attack, she said.

Harsimrat Kaur said she and her children did not know whether they too could have become targets had the assailant succeeded in his alleged attempt.

The August 13 incident was not isolated, she said, recalling the December 4, 2024 attack on Sukhbir Badal at Sri Harmandir Sahib in Amritsar when he was performing religious service as directed by the Akal Takht.

Both incidents occurred at sacred Sikh shrines when Sukhbir Badal was engaged in religious service, Harsimrat

Kaur said, alleging that the attacks were aimed at eliminating a "moderate voice of Punjab" and a proponent of peace and communal harmony. She also raised questions over the Punjab Government's handling of the December 2024 attack.

Referring to the December 4, 2024 incident, she said the criminal and alleged extremist antecedents of the assailant, Narain Singh Chaura, were known to the Punjab Police.

"He has been described as a listed extremist, a self-proclaimed terrorist and an alleged ISI operative. Inputs available to the authorities had also indicated that he had issued threats to eliminate Sukhbir Badal," she said.

Maharashtra FDA sends notice to film stars over Vimal Elaichi advertisement

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra FDA has issued a show-cause notice to actors Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff over their advertisement for Vimal Elaichi, claiming it prima facie amounts to "indirect or surrogate" promotion of prohibited pan masala and tobacco-related products.

The use of the expression "VIMAL Elaichi" in the advertisement appeared to create an association with the Vimal Pan Masala brand and could mislead consumers while indirectly promoting the prohibited product, the Food and Drug Administration (FDA) said.

The issue was particularly serious because the advertisement used the same brand identity associated with Vimal Pan Masala, the FDA's Greater Mumbai division said in the notice issued on August 11, which described the three actors as brand endorsers and sought their response within 15 days.

Terming the notice a "final



warning", it said the advertisement appeared prima facie to be a misleading advertisement relating to food and contrary to provisions of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and the regulations framed under it.

It also flagged possible violations concerning surrogate or indirect advertising under other laws and guidelines.

The FDA has directed the actors to immediately discontinue their participation in and endorsement of the Vimal Pan Masala/Elaichi advertisement and remove the promotional content from their official social media handles, websites and

other digital platforms under their control. It also directed them not to provide any further cooperation or assistance in the broadcasting, publication, dissemination or promotion of the advertisement in any form. The notice further asks the actors to furnish details of the due diligence undertaken by them or their agencies before participating in the campaign.

The action follows the FDA's examination of an advertisement for Vimal Elaichi, which it said was being disseminated through television channels, digital, social media platforms and other promotional media.

Manipur BJP stages protest outside Congress Bhavan over disrespect to national song

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

The Manipur BJP on Sunday staged a demonstration in front of the Congress Bhavan in Imphal to protest against Sonia Gandhi's alleged "objection" to singing of the full version of 'Vande Mataram' during an Independence Day event in New Delhi.

More than 50 BJP workers, holding the national flag and posters of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay, the song's writer, raised slogans and played 'Vande Mataram' on loudspeakers outside the Congress Bhavan.

"The Congress disrespected the national song. We are staging a protest against that. Speaking or moving when the national song is being sung is highly disrespectful," Manipur BJP general secretary K Sarat Kumar Singh told reporters here.

Security was heightened



in the area to prevent any untoward incident, officials said. The BJP has accused former Congress chief Sonia Gandhi of objecting to the singing of the full version of 'Vande Mataram' at an Independence Day event at the opposition party's headquarters in the national capital on Saturday.

However, the Congress denied the charge, asserting that there was no attempt to stop the singing of the full version of the national song, and that Gandhi was only asking for a chair for party chief Mallikarjun Kharge, as he was standing for quite some time.

600 students leave tribal hostel after few show signs of mass hysteria

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Amravati

The authorities in Maharashtra's Amravati district are grappling with an unusual crisis after nearly 600 tribal students left a Government-run hostel at a residential school, claiming that a few girls there were possessed.

The episode began after four girls started behaving strangely on July 22, crying and laughing uncontrollably, which officials suspect could be linked to mental stress.

The tribal residential school at Doma village of Chikhaldara taluka in the tribal-dominated Melghat region in northern Maharashtra, over 700 km from Mumbai, houses 810 boys and girls, said officials on Sunday.

Rumour soon spread that the girls were possessed, prompting about 600 students to leave the "haunted" hostel, run by the Tribal Development Department, over a span of a few days,



they said. According to a hostel source, some of the girls claimed to have heard the sound of anklets clanking.

A senior official from the tribal department said that a team of health experts visited the Doma residential school. "The symptoms have nothing to do with anything supernatural. It could be a selective hysteria-like condition related to mental stress," the official said.

Several theories began floating after the unusual behaviour of some girls, according to a psychological report prepared by the authorities. Some women

from the village also subsequently developed similar mental symptoms, it said.

There is a belief among the students and locals that there was a 'mahua' tree at the site of the ashram school, on which spirits used to reside. The school management cut down the tree, and it is believed that the spirits became angry and were troubling the students, as per the report.

Another reason given was that the temple of their deity behind the ashram school was affected/encroached upon by the school's drainage channel, upsetting the deity.



Editor's
TAKE

Modi's I-Day focus: Youth, reforms and Viksit Bharat

Prime Minister Modi's I-Day speech sought to place India's youth at the centre of Viksit Bharat, unveiling reforms and a series of initiatives

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's address on India's 80th Independence Day – his 13th consecutive speech from the Red Fort, a record for any non-Congress prime minister – was ambitious in scope, familiar in tone. Built around the theme "Yuva Shakti for Viksit Bharat@2047," it unveiled "Shakti ki Sapta Dhara," a seven-point framework spanning manufacturing, agriculture, technology, infrastructure, defence, the green-and-blue economy and soft power, invoking the mythic "Sapta Sindhu" for a fresh current of reform.

The concrete takeaways skewed youth-first: free AI training for one crore young Indians, a Semiconductor Mission promising more fabrication plants within seven-eight years, a nationwide sports talent hunt for children aged 5 to 15 aimed at the 2036 Olympics, and free coaching for competitive exams. On energy, Modi noted that nearly all previously restricted offshore blocks have been opened to exploration, alongside progress on railway electrification and hydrogen trains.

Ceremonially, the full Vande Mataram – marking its 150th anniversary – was sung at the Red Fort for the first time since Independence. Where the speech overreached was its warning about "dimaagi Naxals" – people Modi said carried a "Maoist mindset "while embedded in the "corridors of power," including as advisers on government panels – with a call to identify and isolate them. He left the term undefined, and that vagueness let it be weaponised within hours: BJP spokespersons applied it directly to Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge, who skipped the Red Fort event for a second straight year.

A phrase meant to signal ideological vigilance became, instead, a personalised political jab – a stretch too far for an address meant to unite rather than target named rivals by insinuation. The bigger overreach was ambition standing in for course-correction. The speech arrived two days after a washed-out monsoon session in which Parliament barely debated student unrest, examination-paper leaks, or police action against young protesters. Official data put unemployment among Indians aged 15-29 at a record 16.2 per cent in June, with youth workforce participation sliding from 42.7 to 40.3 per cent over the year.

Against that backdrop, critics read the youth-heavy branding as mere repackaging. The opposition's pushback followed three tracks. Congress called the speech thin on substance: Maharashtra unit chief Harshwardhan Sapkal demanded an account of promises from Modi's previous twelve addresses. Jairam Ramesh dismissed "dimaagi Naxal" as evidence of "desperation," an escalation from the older "urban Naxal" tag. None of this erases the government's genuine claims – India remains, the world's fastest-growing major economy. But a speech meant to inspire ended up generating more heat than throw light on how the state plans to employ the youth it invoked fifty-two times.

Jharkhand students demand justice

Jharkhand's prolonged student agitation is no longer merely a protest over examination irregularities. What began with anger over alleged leaks and discrepancies in recruitment examinations has evolved into a broader expression of frustration over jobs, education, transparency and political representation



KALYANI SHANKAR

In recent years, Jharkhand has seen a rise in student activism driven by a growing awareness of social issues and the need for better representation. The student protests, which followed the rise of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP), at the all India level, marked a turning point in Jharkhand's socio-political narrative. Students recently organised protests after the unexpected rise of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP). These protests targeted issues in the education system, including the leak of question papers in NEET and other exams. The current political situation has encouraged young people to speak out about their frustrations and demands regarding the state's social and economic problems.

The student protests followed the rise of the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) and mark a significant moment in Jharkhand's social and political landscape. This student group is not just asking for better education and job opportunities; they want to be heard in the political conversation. They are fighting for a future where their voices matter, and their rights are respected.

Since July 25, protesters have gathered at a stadium in Ranchi, Jharkhand. Many have been sleeping outside, and some have begun hunger strikes. Many have been sleeping outside, and some have initiated hunger strikes. Protesters are committed to continuing until all their demands are met. Their anger stems from a preliminary civil service exam held by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) in April. After the results were announced in July, candidates said leaked answer sheets on social media showed that some successful applicants answered fewer questions than expected. The CJP ended its five-week protest on July 25 with the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan.

The CJP's achievements energised students, giving them a chance to voice their concerns about education, jobs, and social justice in Jharkhand—issues that the CJP highlighted. By pushing for transparency, accountability, and local involvement, the CJP resonated with students eager for change.

During the protests, students expressed their frustration with the declining quality of education in Jharkhand's institutions. Many protested against overcrowded classrooms, a lack of resources, and insufficient faculty, demanding immediate reforms to create a better educational environment.

Amid economic uncertainty, students pointed out the high unemployment rate, especially among graduates. They urged the government



THE IMMEDIATE CAUSE OF THEIR ANGER IS A PRELIMINARY CIVIL SERVICE EXAM HELD BY THE JHARKHAND PUBLIC SERVICE COMMISSION (JPSC) IN APRIL. AFTER THE RESULTS WERE ANNOUNCED IN JULY, CANDIDATES ALLEGED THAT LEAKED ANSWER SHEETS SHARED ON SOCIAL MEDIA INDICATED THAT SOME SUCCESSFUL APPLICANTS HAD ANSWERED SIGNIFICANTLY FEWER QUESTIONS THAN EXPECTED

The writer is a popular columnist

to create job opportunities and asked the CJP to prioritise youth employment.

The protests attracted a diverse group of students from various colleges and universities across Jharkhand. They used social media to organise rallies, marches, and awareness campaigns. Students have actively participated in demonstrations for more than two weeks, advocating for comprehensive reforms to the government examination system in Jharkhand. This newly energised student body is not only demanding better educational and job opportunities but is also asserting its place in the state's political discourse. They are advocating for a future where their voices are heard, and their rights are respected.

The immediate cause of their anger is a preliminary civil service exam held by the Jharkhand Public Service Commission (JPSC) in April. After the results were announced in July, candidates alleged that leaked answer sheets shared on social media indicated that some successful applicants had answered significantly fewer questions than expected.

The success of the CJP catalysed student mobilisation in Jharkhand also, allowing them to express their concerns over critical issues of education, employment, and social justice in Jharkhand—issues that the CJP had notably addressed. By advocating for transparency, accountability, and grassroots participation, the CJP resonated with students and young people eager for change.

During the protests, students voiced their dissatisfaction with the declining quality of education in institutions across Jharkhand. Many protested against overcrowded classrooms, a lack of resources, and insufficient faculty, demanding immediate reforms to ensure a better educational environment.

Amid economic uncertainty, students highlighted the alarming rate of unemployment, particularly among graduates. They called for government intervention to create job oppor-

tunities and urged the CJP to prioritise youth employment in its agenda. Students demanded greater representation and involvement in the political process, expressing that the voices of the youth were often marginalised in decision-making. They advocated for platforms that encourage youth participation and ensure their concerns are addressed.

The protests attracted a diverse group of students from various colleges and universities across Jharkhand. Utilising social media as an effective tool for organisation, they coordinated rallies, marches, and awareness campaigns. This visibility was crucial in amplifying their demands and bringing their issues to the forefront of public discourse.

As Jharkhand student agitation enters Day 20, job aspirants demand a CBI probe and the total cancellation of JPSC and JSSC recruitment exams. Protesting students, including Devendra Mahto and Manoj Yadav, have threatened to demonstrate before the Chief Minister's residence after August 15th. An FIR has been registered against 100 named individuals and 500 unidentified protester

Meanwhile ABVP, the student wing has said it would stage demonstrations at over 1,200 universities and in every district across the country. expanding the scope of the protests. The ABVP will resort to a phase-wise agitation across the country if a CBI probe into the job exam irregularities is not held. While the CJP movement is called Gen Z protest, The Jharkhand movement has a significant presence of an older generation of aspirants—millennials and others. It is not only youthful impatience. It is accumulated frustration. At Jantar Mantar, students were protesting against a BJP-led government at the Centre. The movement became increasingly confrontational and the police response became an important part of the story.

In Jharkhand, the political equation is different and a non-BJP government is facing the students. A new twist is (CJP) has joined the ongoing student agitation in Jharkhand, with a party delegation reaching the protest site in Ranchi.

They declared "complete solidarity" with Jharkhand students. With the government holding talks but protesters refusing to call off their demonstrations, the coming days are likely to determine whether negotiations can break the deadlock.

For now, the students continue to demand accountability and corrective action over the recruitment examination process, while the state government says it will consider the issues raised by the protesting groups.

PIC TALK



Armed Forces personnel during the 80th Independence Day celebrations, at Red Fort in New Delhi

PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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INDEPENDENCE DAY: FREEDOM COMES WITH RESPONSIBILITY

The Sepoy mutiny of 1857 triggered India's fight for independence. Its rebellion against the British East India Company between 1857 – 1858 is a significant milestone in the struggle for freedom. Also known as India's first war of independence, the one year and six months revolt may not have yielded results in the sheer sense of the term but the rebellion was just the kind of boost required for the forefathers of Indian freedom struggle to take over.

As the country is geared up to celebrate the 80th Independence day on August 15, the supreme sacrifice and patience, not to mention the courage, of our freedom fathers deserve to be emulated.

Every Indian citizen should draw inspiration from what the freedom fighters did and how they achieved their goals with unflinching dedication and fierce determination.

At the stroke of midnight between August 14 and August 15, when the country's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru delivered his famous "Tryst with destiny" speech, entire India held its head high, and many may have had emotional goosebumps.

Nehru's "when the world sleeps, India will wake to life" cannot be easily erased from the psyche of an Indian. Independence day is a duty, a responsibility – to convert India into a country that others look up to.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

Questions about employee attrition have become increasingly common in leadership discussions. Organisations invest heavily in understanding why talented people leave and what it takes to persuade them to stay. During one such conversation recently, I found myself reflecting on a very different workplace culture I had experienced more than four decades earlier, when I began my career in the Railways.

A senior officer accompanied me during the daily rounds of the maintenance shed for the first two weeks. At the end of the fortnight, he simply said, "From Monday, you are on your own." The shed and its staff were now my responsibility. Yet I was never really alone. Whenever difficult issues arose—whether with the trade unions or the Headquarters—I knew the senior officers stood firmly behind me. That

The quiet power of belonging

culture remained consistent throughout my years in the Railways. Senior officers backed difficult decisions, corrected mistakes without humiliation and encouraged me to take on unfamiliar responsibilities with confidence. These experiences made me feel that I belonged. I realised later that these small gestures influenced me more than I recognised at the time. I found myself offering the same support to younger colleagues, not because anyone asked me to, but because someone had once done the same for me.

When I entered the private sector nearly twenty-five years later, the workplace had changed considerably. Careers had become more mobile, organisations more dynamic, and restructuring more common. These changes brought many advantages—greater opportunities, faster growth and increased flexibility. I sensed that something less tangible—but equally important—was becoming harder to preserve: the sense of being connected to something larger than oneself. Many employers invest significant resources in designing performance management systems, incentives and retention strategies. These have an important place in every organisation. But they sometimes underestimate the influence of small human gestures—an encouraging conversation, thoughtful guidance, genuine appreciation or a senior taking an interest in someone's growth. Such moments create something that policies alone cannot: a lasting emotional connection with the organisation. Belonging cannot be mandated through organisational charts or employee handbooks. It develops when people feel that they matter beyond the role they perform.

Employees who experience that connection are often willing to contribute more than what is contractually expected because they begin to identify with its purpose as their own. Perhaps this becomes even more important during mergers and acquisitions. Structures, reporting lines and systems can be integrated relatively quickly. Trust, identity and belonging cannot. Unless people feel seen during periods of change, uncertainty often weakens commitment long before performance indicators begin to reflect it.

These experiences also made me reflect on a broader question. In a world where careers are increasingly fluid and professional relationships often shorter than before, organisations may need to invest as much in creating belonging as they do in improving efficiency. Technology can make work faster. Incentives can improve performance. But it is often another human being who determines whether someone merely works for an organisation—or truly feels part of it. Looking back, I realise that what has stayed with me is not a policy, a promotion or even a particular achievement. It is the confidence others placed in me, often quietly. Perhaps that is what people remember longest—not the advice they receive, but the trust they are shown and the feeling they were valued. Organisations change, careers move on, but those experiences continue to shape how people lead, work and inspire others.

The writer is a founder of Kala - Crazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Bar Council's Nalsar decision was unfortunate

The Bar Council of India's decision to temporarily halt the enrollment of 2026 graduates of Nalsar University of Law, reportedly because they opposed the university's invitation to Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, was unfortunate and legally questionable.

Though the decision has since been rescinded, it raises important questions about the limits of the Bar Council's authority and also about the right of students to protests. The Advocates Act empowers the Council to regulate professional conduct and standards among advocates. However, Nalsar students had not yet become advocates. The Council may frame rules concerning legal education, but this does not give it the authority to judge students' personal choices or moral conduct. In a democratic set up, the right to peacefully protest is sacrosanct and so cannot be penalised by the powers that be.

The decision to withdraw the order was therefore welcome. Every student should have the freedom to decide from whom they wish to receive their degree certificate. Declining to accept a certificate from a judge cannot amount to contempt, since distributing degrees is an academic, not judicial, function.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Terrorism remains the biggest barrier

A recent Pew Research Center survey highlights the deep mistrust between India and Pakistan. While a large majority of Pakistanis view India as an existential threat, Indians too continue to regard Pakistan as a major security challenge.

Following the Pahalgam attack, bilateral relations have deteriorated further. For Pakistan, the persistent Kashmir and jihad rhetoric appears to serve domestic political purposes.

Yet such rhetoric cannot provide answers to the pressing concerns of ordinary citizens—employment, infrastructure, healthcare, education and economic growth. The experience of several resource-rich theocratic countries demonstrates that economic resources alone cannot guarantee inclusive development.

A sustainable future requires separating governance from religious extremism and ensuring that development remains the central priority. Unless Islamabad takes credible action against terrorism, meaningful improvement in bilateral relations will remain difficult. Peace requires both countries to move beyond hostility and focus on the welfare of their people.

NEELAM JAISWAL | DEWAS

Provide moral support to persons with disabilities

Persons with disabilities need not merely physical assistance but also understanding, dignity and moral support. Society must recognise the individual before the disability and avoid language that reduces a person to a medical condition. Our attitudes often create a greater handicap than the physical limitation itself. When people are taught to view themselves only through the lens of their disability, their confidence and potential can suffer.

Acceptance, encouragement and opportunities can help them overcome these psychological barriers. Movement-related disabilities constitute a significant proportion of physical disabilities, while hearing and visual impairments also affect many people. The decline in movement disabilities among younger children may partly reflect the success of India's polio immunisation programme.

Moreover, better treatments have also been a factor to enable people to move. We must therefore create an inclusive environment in schools, workplaces and communities. Compassion, accessibility and equal opportunity can help persons with disabilities live with dignity and realise their full potential.

JAYANTHY SUBRAMANIAM | MUMBAI

India@80: The Independence story we need to know

India did not become free because the British suddenly accepted the moral case for self-rule. Independence emerged from a far more turbulent convergence of anti-colonial resistance, wartime exhaustion, economic crisis, political calculations, communal mobilisation and growing doubts about the Raj's ability to command obedience.



Unlike many countries that count their independence by anniversaries, India has developed a peculiar habit of counting its freedom in ordinal numbers. The United States, for example, celebrated its 250th anniversary in 2026, marking two and a half centuries since independence. India, by contrast, calls 15 August 2026 its 80th Independence

Day, although the country became independent in 1947 and this is therefore the 79th anniversary of independence. The language of the 80th Independence Day suggests a continuous national ritual in which each passing year is another instalment of a story already settled. Yet India's independence was anything but settled. It was born from an extraordinary collision of anti-colonial resistance, imperial exhaustion, famine, political calculation, communal mobilisation, ideological disagreement, international pressure and personal rivalries.

The British Empire did not simply relinquish India because the moral case for independence had finally become irresistible. By the end of the Second World War, Britain faced a more practical question than whether Indians wanted freedom. It was whether Britain still possessed the political, economic and coercive capacity to govern India indefinitely. Independence was therefore both a nationalist victory and the retreat of an exhausted empire.

Few episodes expose the contradictions of British rule more brutally than the Bengal famine of 1943. Crop failures, the 1942 cyclone, wartime disruption, inflation, procurement policies, transport constraints and the loss of rice imports after the Japanese occupation of Burma all played roles. But political decisions made during the crisis cannot be separated from the catastrophe. Churchill's government prioritised the demands of a global war in which India was treated as an imperial resource while Indians had no equivalent political authority over the allocation of those resources. Indians were being asked to participate in the defence of an empire whose political system did not give their lives equal weight in the calculation of wartime priorities.

The surviving record becomes darker still when the language of imperial officials is examined. In his diary, Secretary of State for India Leopold Amery recorded Churchill making a remark about Indians "breeding like rabbits" during discussions over famine relief. Amery was so appalled by Churchill's attitude towards India that he wrote privately that, on the subject of India, Winston was "not quite sane" and compared his outlook with Hitler's. Millions were starving while the allocation of ships, grain and other resources was being argued over in terms of military necessity, imperial priorities and competing claims on British shipping. The famine was therefore not merely a humanitarian disaster. It exposed what imperial government meant when the population affected by a decision had no sovereign authority over it. Churchill did not merely oppose a timetable for Indian self-government. He opposed the underlying historical direction. He famously declared that he had not become the King's First Minister in order to preside over the liquidation of the British Empire. For Churchill, empire was not an incidental possession. India remained one of its essential foundations.

India's side is no less troubling. Maulana Abul Kalam Azad remains one of the most consequential figures to disappear into the background of the conventional independence narrative. His opposition to Pakistan was not based on a denial of Muslim identity. He argued from within an Islamic intellectual framework that a Muslim had no reason to surrender India because political territory could not be divided neatly into the pure and the impure. He regarded the whole of India as his political inheritance. For Azad, Muslim identity and Indian nationhood were not incompatible propositions.

Azad believed that Congress had been offered a constitutional route that could have preserved Indian unity while accommodating substantial political autonomy for Muslim-majority regions. Nehru's insistence that the Constituent Assembly would ultimately be free to alter the arrangement, Azad argued, gave Jinnah the opportunity to claim that the safeguards offered to Muslims were unreliable. In Azad's judgement, this was one of the greatest tragedies of Indian history. He went further, arguing



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The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

that Nehru had committed an "almost equal blunder" in 1937 and that the consequences of Congress's decisions in the United Provinces helped give the Muslim League a new lease of political life. Partition, in this reading, was not simply the inevitable result of an ancient Hindu-Muslim antagonism. Political decisions made by nationalist leaders helped narrow the alternatives.

Azad himself differed from Gandhi on war and strategy. He regarded non-violence as a policy rather than an absolute creed and argued that Indians had the right to fight if circumstances required it. He also warned Gandhi that Japanese forces approaching India could not simply be regarded as enemies of the British rather than potential enemies of India. He found himself in the extraordinary position of having earlier urged organised opposition to Britain while later warning that Gandhi's proposed strategy, once Japanese forces approached India's frontier, was dangerously unrealistic.

Gandhi could regard non-violence as a moral principle, while Azad could regard it largely as a political method. Nehru could view the Second World War through the global confrontation between fascism and democracy, while Azad insisted that India's own freedom remained paramount. C. Rajagopalachari openly dissented from Congress policy and argued that accommodation with the Muslim League might unlock the constitutional deadlock. Jinnah moved from constitutional politics towards a mass-based demand for Pakistan. Patel pursued political calculations that Azad regarded as falling short of Congress's professed nationalism.

Meanwhile, even some Europeans concluded that loyalty to justice required opposition to empire. Annie Besant, an Englishwoman, became one of India's most prominent advocates of self-government. Benjamin Guy Horniman, another Englishman, identified so closely with Indian political grievances that he publicly aligned himself with the nationalist cause. American missionary Samuel Stokes went further, adopting Indian practices and entering the nationalist struggle.

Then there was Shapurji Saklatvala, the British-Indian communist politician whose political relationship with Gandhi was far from harmonious. Saklatvala belonged to a political tradition that viewed Gandhian methods with suspicion. Constitutionalists, revolutionaries, socialists, communists, religious nationalists, secular nationalists and advocates of non-violence disagreed profoundly about what freedom should produce. The British Empire was weakened not by one argument but by the accumulation of contradictions.

An empire claiming to fight fascism could not indefinitely deny political freedom to its largest colony. A government demanding Indian resources could not easily explain why Indian political authority remained subordinate. A state dependent on Indian soldiers could not ignore changing loyalties within the armed forces. By 1946, the Royal Indian Navy revolt demonstrated how dangerous that transformation could become. It was not the sole cause of British withdrawal, but it was an unmistakable warning that the coercive foundations of colonial rule were becoming unstable. The empire had survived earlier rebellions because it could rely upon the obedience of its soldiers and police. That obedience could no longer be taken for granted. The deeper meaning of 1947 is therefore not that one man defeated an empire, nor that one organisation liberated a nation, nor even that Partition was unavoidable. India became independent because an enormous imperial structure had been weakened from several directions while Indians themselves were arguing fiercely over what should replace it. That is why the overlooked history matters. It asks why an empire that proclaimed liberty ruled India for so long, why famine coexisted with imperial priorities, and why the Raj ultimately lost the loyalty on which its power depended. The flag raised in 1947 represented freedom, but also the end of several competing visions of what India could become. Some disappeared with the empire. Others disappeared with Partition.

When schools disappear, so do dreams



ABHINAV
NARAYAN JHA

DIVYANSHU
BHARDWAJ

India's journey as the world's largest democracy has been inseparable from its commitment to public education. For decades, government schools have served as the first classrooms for millions of children, particularly those from rural, tribal, and economically weaker communities. For generations, the neighbourhood government school symbolised aspiration rather than privilege. It offered every child, irrespective of caste, class or geography—a fair chance to succeed.

Today, however, this foundational pillar of the Republic faces an unprecedented challenge. According to analyses of UDISE+ data and highlighted in NITI Aayog's report on the School Education System in India, nearly 94,000 government schools have ceased functioning over the last decade, averaging nearly 25 closures per day. Many of these closures have occurred due to mergers, rationalisation, and consolidation aimed at improving efficiency. Yet the scale of this transformation raises a constitutional and policy question that deserves national attention: Can India fulfil its promise of universal education? At the same time, its public school network steadily contracts.

Education occupies a unique position in India's constitutional framework. Through the Eighty-Sixth Constitutional Amendment, Parliament inserted Article 21A, making free and compulsory education for children between six and fourteen years a Fundamental Right. The Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education Act, 2009 (RTE Act) transformed this constitutional guarantee into an enforceable legal obligation. Additionally, Articles 41, 45 and 46 of the Directive Principles require the State to promote education, provide early childhood care and protect the educational interests of weaker sections. Even before Article 21A came into force, the Supreme Court had recognised education as intrinsic to the right to life under Article 21. In *Mohini Jain v. State of Karnataka* (1992) and *Unni Krishnan v. State of Andhra Pradesh* (1993), the Court observed that meaningful enjoyment of other fundamental rights becomes impossible without access to education. Public education is a constitutional responsibility. Viewed through this constitutional lens, the closure of government schools deserves scrutiny. In thousands of villages, the government primary school remains the only educational institution within accessible distance. Once such schools are merged or closed, children often have to travel significantly farther every day.

For older students, this may be inconvenient; for younger children, it can become prohibitive. Girls, children with disabilities, and those belonging to economically weaker households are particularly vulnerable. Longer travel distances, lack of safe transport, and additional costs frequently translate into irregular attendance, higher dropout rates, and poorer learning outcomes. Accessibility is not merely a logistical concern—it determines whether the constitutional right to education can be exercised in practice. Government schools also perform functions that extend far beyond classroom teaching. They serve as centres for the Mid-Day Meal Scheme, vaccination drives, disaster relief, elections, public health campaigns and community gatherings. More importantly, they remain among the few institutions where children from different castes, religions and economic backgrounds study together, strengthening social cohesion and democratic values.

Nevertheless, any balanced discussion must acknowledge the government's rationale behind school rationalisation. Declining fertility rates, migration from villages to urban centres, teacher shortages, and falling enrollment in several regions have created schools with very few students. Maintaining separate infrastructure and teaching staff for such institutions may not always represent the most effective use of public resources.

These considerations deserve serious attention. However, administrative efficiency cannot become an end in itself. If school mergers result in children discontinuing education because the nearest classroom has moved beyond practical reach, constitutional objectives stand compromised irrespective of administrative savings. Rationalisation must therefore remain a means to strengthen education—not a mechanism that unintentionally restricts access. Recent reports by NITI Aayog, UDISE+, the Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) and the National Achievement Survey (NAS) continue to identify challenges relating to teacher vacancies, infrastructure deficits, foundational literacy, digital inequality and regional disparities. These concerns suggest that India's education system requires sustained public investment and institutional strengthening rather than merely reducing the number of schools. The way forward requires balanced, evidence-based reforms. Any decision to merge or close schools should be preceded by a social impact assessment, considering distance, accessibility, gender and dropout risks. Teacher vacancies must be filled urgently, while rural schools need better infrastructure, digital connectivity and basic facilities. School Management Committees should be empowered to strengthen local participation and accountability.

India today aspires to become a developed nation under the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. Public schools remain India's most powerful instrument of social justice. Weakening this network without adequate safeguards risks widening educational disparities at precisely the moment when India seeks inclusive growth. The real objective should be to preserve the constitutional philosophy that no child's educational opportunity should depend upon geography, income or social background. The closure of nearly 94,000 government schools over the past decade should serve as a moment of reflection rather than political confrontation.

India's constitutional promise was never simply to educate children—it was to ensure that every child, regardless of birthplace or circumstance, enjoys an equal opportunity to realise his or her potential. That promise deserves not only preservation but renewed national commitment.

Abhinav is an advocate and Columnist based in New Delhi and Divyanshu is an advocate based out of Delhi



Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train: A new lifeline for India's growing cities



PRATEEK
VAIBHAV

The Mumbai-Ahmedabad Bullet Train is not simply a faster train project; it is being built as a new transportation lifeline connecting some of western India's most important economic centres.

The 508-km Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail corridor is expected to transform the way people travel between Mumbai, Thane, Virar, Palghar, Boisar, Surat, Vadodara, Ahmedabad and other cities along the route.

City Centre to City Centre Travel

One of the biggest advantages of the Bullet Train will be its city-centre-to-city-centre connectivity. Instead of relying on airports far from urban centres, passengers will be able to reach major business and residential areas via strategically located high-speed rail stations. The Mumbai station at Bandra-Kurla Complex is particularly significant because BKC is one of Mumbai's major commercial districts. The underground station will also connect with the city's metro network and road transport. Similarly, stations at Surat, Vadodara and Ahmedabad will bring high-speed rail closer

to the heart of the cities they serve.

This can make the journey more convenient, especially for daily or frequent travelers. A New Lifeline for Middle-Class Passengers: The bullet train is often associated with premium travel, but its larger impact could be felt by India's growing middle class.

As cities expand and employment opportunities become concentrated in major urban centres, affordable and reliable intercity transportation becomes increasingly important.

The Bullet Train can provide for passengers travelling frequently for work, education, business or family commitments, which could significantly improve mobility. The corridor can also strengthen economic opportunities in cities and towns along the route by making it easier for people to travel between residential areas and major employment centres.

Relief from Heavy Traffic in Major Cities

Mumbai, Ahmedabad, Surat and Vadodara are major economic centres that experience substantial road and rail congestion.



A high-speed rail system can shift a portion of long-distance passenger traffic away from roads and conventional rail services. Better integration between high-speed rail stations, metro systems, buses, and other public transport can encourage passengers to leave their private vehicles behind and use a more integrated public transportation network.

Time Savings for Greater Mumbai Commuters

The project could be particularly important for commuters and residents in the wider

Mumbai Metropolitan Region.

Cities and towns such as Thane, Virar, Boisar and Palghar are increasingly connected to Mumbai through employment, education and business.

Reducing overall travel time between regional centres and major employment hubs will be a big relief for the daily commuters from these places.

The integration of high speed, metro, bus could make the Mumbai region function more like a connected metropolitan economic zone rather than a col

lection of separate cities.

Engineering Marvels Taking Shape

Perhaps the most fascinating aspect of the project is the scale and complexity of the engineering work taking place. The Mumbai section includes a 21-km underground tunnel between BKC and Shilphata.

This section is being constructed using massive Tunnel Boring Machines & NATM. Approximately seven kilometres will pass beneath Thane Creek, making it India's first undersea rail tunnel.

The TBMs being used are engineering giants, with cutterheads measuring 13.6 metres in diameter and machines weighing around 3,200 tonnes. Advanced Mixshield technology is being used to control ground settlement while tunnelling beneath densely populated urban areas and critical infrastructure.

The project is also introducing advanced Japanese-inspired J-Slab ballastless track technology in India. The system is designed for stable high-speed operation, with precision-engineered track slabs, rails and Cement Asphalt Mortar. Noise barriers are another important feature.

Around six lakh noise barriers have already been installed along approximately 297 km of the corridor. These barriers are designed to reduce the impact of high-speed train operations on surrounding communities. The electrification system is equally ambitious. The corridor is adopting a 2x25 kV overhead traction system, supported by thousands of masts and sophisticated electrical infrastructure designed for trains operating at speeds of up to 320 km/h.

The engineering achievement is impressive, but the real test of the project will be how effectively it improves everyday mobility for the millions of people living and working across Mumbai, Gujarat and the surrounding regions.

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Order Order

Delhi tribunal awards ₹2.92 crore to road accident victim



A Motor Accident Claims Tribunal (MACT) here has awarded compensation of over ₹2.92 crore to a 32-year-old marketing executive, who suffered 88 per cent permanent disability in a road accident in 2020.

It trashed the insurer's argument that the victim was negligent because he was not wearing a helmet, saying it cannot be said to be a ground for contributory negligence. "A violation of traffic law cannot be said to be contributory negligence without any evidence in support showing that the violation has led to the accident," the Tribunal said.

Presiding Officer Abhilash Malhotra was hearing the claim petition of Nilmani Chauhan, who suffered 88 per cent permanent disability because of a traumatic spinal cord injury, leaving him unable to stand or walk for the rest of his life. According to Chauhan's plea, he was grievously injured after a car being driven in a rash and negligent manner rammed into his two-wheeler on December 30, 2020.

In an order dated August 12, the court said, "It is already proved on record that the lower body of the injured has become dysfunctional. He is dependent upon an attendant for passing urine as he cannot feel the same, and his employer stated that they are providing him salary on humanitarian grounds till the time this case is decided."

The Tribunal said that, from the nature of injuries ("Traumatic spinal cord injury with Paraplegia with Neurogenic Bladder"), it is clear that the injured will never be able to perform the job of marketing executive, which involves considerable movement, and the desk job will also be dependent upon the services of a full-time attendant. The Tribunal held the car driver, Ramesh, responsible for "rash and negligent driving" while directing the insurance company IFFCO Tokio General Insurance Co Ltd to pay an amount of over ₹2.92 crore, including interest, and covering various heads, such as loss of future earnings, medical treatment, and attendant charges. It trashed the insurer's argument that the victim was negligent because he was not wearing a helmet. "Merely because the injured was not wearing a helmet, the same cannot be said to be ground for contributory negligence. A violation of traffic law cannot be said to be contributory negligence without any evidence in support showing that the violation has led to the accident," the tribunal said. (PTI)

HC denies anticipatory bail to man in trafficking case



The Delhi High Court has denied anticipatory bail to a man facing prosecution in a human-trafficking case, in which he allegedly married the victim forcibly.

The court dismissed the anticipatory bail plea, saying the allegations against him are serious and at this stage, it cannot be inferred that he was lawfully married to the victim. "Keeping in mind the nature of the allegations and the fact that, as per the prosecution, it is a case of human trafficking, custodial interrogation of the applicant would be imperative," Justice Manoj Jain said in an order passed on August 11. The court noted that the allegations are "very serious" and "alarming", and said there is no merit or substance in the application. According to the prosecution, two men had sexually assaulted the 17-year-old victim and "sold" her to applicant-accused Sukhram for ₹30,000.

The victim had claimed that she was sexually assaulted by the two men, taken to Uttar Pradesh and forcibly married to an aged Sukhram. A case was registered by police for the alleged offences of kidnapping, human trafficking and sexual assault on a complaint from the victim's uncle.

The prosecutor submitted that two accused have already been arrested and are in custody, and another one was granted bail as there were no allegations of sexual assault against him. He added that the accused, including the applicant, had taken undue advantage of the victim's young age and her mental condition. (PTI)

Pune court remands drug kingpin Virender Singh Basoya to NCB custody till August 21

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Pune

A Pune court on Sunday remanded alleged drug kingpin Virender Singh Basoya, who was recently extradited from the UAE, to the NCB's custody till August 21.

A Delhi court on Friday allowed the Narcotics Control Bureau's (NCB) plea seeking three-day transit remand of Basoya, accused in a multi-crore drug haul, to produce him before a Pune court. On Sunday, Basoya was

produced before a Pune court under heavy police security. The prosecution told the court that the accused stayed abroad for a long time. His name has surfaced in several drug-related cases and there is a possibility that he is a key figure in a major drug trafficking racket. Supplying narcotic drugs is a serious offence, the prosecution noted, adding that around 9,000 kg of mephedrone had been seized during operations carried out by the NCB and the police.

The Pune Police had also seized a large quantity of drugs during operations in Vishrantwadi (Pune) and Delhi. There are multiple accused in this case, and Basoya needs to be interrogated about the role of all the other accused. The search for the remaining accused in this case is also underway, the prosecution said and sought Basoya's NCB custody for six days. Basoya's lawyer, however, said his client should be remanded to only four days of NCB custody.



After hearing both sides, the court remanded Basoya to NCB's custody till August 21. Basoya's name had surfaced in a seizure of 500 grams of mephedrone, a synthetic stimulant commonly known by the street name "meow meow", in Pune in 2024. The probe was later expanded to identify and dismantle the entire drug trafficking network, resulting in the recovery of approximately 867 kg of mephedrone from Pune and 970 kg from Delhi, taking the total recovery to

approximately 1,837 kg. The NCB's Mumbai unit took over the investigation and identified Basoya as the alleged mastermind who coordinated activities of the syndicate from foreign shores and smuggled out mephedrone consignments from India to other countries. His name also cropped up in a separate case of the Delhi Police Special Cell related to international cocaine trafficking. Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday said the NCB

secured the return of Basoya from the UAE, creating a "new milestone" in the policy of zero tolerance against narcotics. NCB Deputy Director General (operations) Neeraj Gupta had said that Basoya escaped to Dubai just a day after the Pune police registered a case against him in 2024. Basoya is a "big kingpin" of the drug trafficking network against whom an Interpol Red Notice was issued in November 2025, Gupta added.



BCI: The fallout of a solo diktat



RANJIT KUMAR SINHA

The Bar Council of India (BCI) has hogged the limelight recently for the wrong reasons. Its Chairman, Manan Kumar Mishra, is facing the wrath of the nation. The reason is his diktat, first directing State Bar Councils across India not to enrol any 2026 graduating students of the NALSAR University of Law, Hyderabad, as advocates.

This controversial directive was issued following a student campaign and protests objecting to the university's invitation of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant as the chief guest for its convocation.

The move drew widespread backlash from the legal fraternity and student bodies for imposing a collective penalty on an entire batch, leading the BCI to withdraw the order and its Chairman, Manan Kumar Mishra, to subsequently issue an apology.

The controversy soon reached the Supreme Court. A bench led by Chief Justice Surya Kant examined the issue and made strong observations. The CJ bluntly stated that the BCI had "no business" interfering in university student protests.

The CJ emphasized that peaceful protests are a right and that students cannot be punished for expressing their views. The bench barred any coercive action against the students or faculty.

The BCI Chairman also faced direct criticism from the leadership of the Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA). SCBA President and Senior Advocate Vikas Singh wrote a sharp letter questioning the move. He called the ban illegal

and arbitrary, and criticised the BCI for targeting the future careers of young graduates.

Singh stressed that a national regulatory body cannot use collective punishment to stifle free speech.

Legal experts and constitutional scholars were quick to point out that this arbitrary exercise of power dealt a severe blow to the BCI's institutional integrity.

By reducing a national regulatory body to an instrument of personal retaliation, the episode exposed alarming vulnerabilities in how apex professional bodies can be manipulated without internal checks and balances.

Under the Advocates Act, 1961, the BCI operates as a statutory regulatory body governed by collective decision-making, predefined rules, and principles of natural justice. The Chairman's office possesses no emergency or arbitrary powers to single-handedly suspend or bar an entire graduating batch from enrolment. The ensuing outrage was not merely about the heavy-handed treatment of law students, but about the dangerous precedent set when leadership abandons statutory accountability in favour of unilateral diktats.

This episode has reignited a broader, much-needed national debate concerning the autonomy, transparency, and accountability of India's apex legal regulatory bodies.

Critics argue that when statutory authorities tasked with upholding the rule of law choose to bypass democratic deliberation and institutional safeguards, they fundamentally undermine their own legitimacy.

As calls for internal reform and stricter governance grow louder, the NALSAR controversy serves as a stark reminder that professional regulatory bodies must remain strictly anchored in statutory pro-



cedure rather than arbitrary personal authority. With the directive withdrawn and an apology tendered, the immediate crisis has subsided, but the core systemic questions remain wide open.

Legal professionals and student organizations are now pushing for institutional safeguards to ensure that the powers vested in office-bearers are never again weaponised on a whim.

Civil society and legal forums are increasingly demanding statutory amendments or internal accountability mechanisms that mandate collective voting and public disclosure of all policy-level circulars. Ensuring that regulatory bodies remain insulated from personal vendettas or executive overreach is vital for preserving the trust of the legal community and the public at large. Ultimately, the incident has highlighted that the true strength of an apex institution lies not in the unchecked authority of its leaders, but in its steadfast adherence to democratic process, transparency, and the rule of law.

Beyond his role at the BCI, Mishra is also a Member of

Parliament in the Rajya Sabha from the BJP. Many critics believe his harsh order had political motives, noting that the ban looked like an attempt to please political interests by targeting students who questioned authority. This was not a one-time incident. In the past, Mishra has often used the BCI platform to make politically charged statements. He has frequently invited criticism for using the BCI's official platform and letterhead to issue politically polarized statements. Several key instances highlight this pattern. During political street agitations (such as public protests at Jantar Mantar), Mishra issued an aggressive public statement on the BCI letterhead. He claimed the protests were hijacked by "anti-national elements" and foreign adversaries trying to destabilize India, drawing fierce pushback from lawyers who felt a neutral professional body should not take political sides.

In December 2019, during nationwide anti-CAA (Citizenship Amendment Act) protests, Mishra signed a formal BCI letter express-

ing strong solidarity with the police and armed forces, and calling on bar leaders and students to suppress the protests. Once again, groups of lawyers publicly objected, pointing out that using the BCI platform for partisan political narratives was a disservice to the legal profession.

When prominent senior advocates and legal figures openly criticized certain judicial developments or decisions, Mishra frequently issued sharp, lengthy retorts on behalf of the BCI.

Critics argued these statements read less like neutral regulatory actions and more like targeted political attacks against critics of the government, and that turning a professional legal regulator into a tool for politics damages the dignity of the entire legal fraternity.

Mishra has headed the BCI for a long tenure spanning roughly 14 years. Over this extended period, he has been re-elected multiple times. However, this latest episode has brought his leadership under severe introspection.

Following the controversial NALSAR directive, sections of lawyers' bodies and legal forums have openly called for his resignation. Critics feel that staying at the helm for too long has created an environment lacking internal accountability.

Many within the legal community express concern that his primary focus has increasingly shifted toward party politics rather than the core welfare of lawyers and legal education. Observers note that an apex regulatory body requires undivided attention to solve deep-seated professional challenges, rather than getting entangled in political alignments and external controversies.

The author is a senior journalist in legal affairs

Cauvery row: SC to hear Tamil Nadu plea on Monday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea of the Tamil Nadu government seeking directions to the Karnataka government for immediate release of its share of Cauvery water to it.

According to the top court's cause list of August 17, the matter would come up for hearing before a bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta.

On August 12, the apex court had said pleas filed in the matter by the Tamil Nadu government and others, including the DMK, would be taken up for hearing on August 17. Earlier, the Tamil Nadu government had said the state was not getting its due share of Cauvery water in a rain-deficient year. The Joseph Vijay-



led State Government on August 3 approached the apex court seeking directions to the Karnataka Government for immediate release of the water.

The state government, in its plea, claimed that the quantum allocated to it by the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee

(CWRC) as well as that released by its neighbour Karnataka was far less.

A CWRC meeting held on July 28 directed Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs for 15 days starting July 29. However, the quantum of water released at Biligundlu ranged between 158 and 550 cusecs from July 29 to

August 2, the state government said.

A press release issued by the Tamil Nadu government said that as of August 3, the combined total storage in the reservoirs in Karnataka -- KRS, Kabini, Harangi and Hemavathy -- stood at 77,537 TMC and Karnataka would face no difficulty in releasing Tamil Nadu's due share proportionately. Following rains in the catchment areas in the KRS and Kabini dams in Karnataka recently, the proportionate water to be realised at Biligundlu should be 26,954 TMC, it said.

"Accordingly, the Cauvery Water Management Authority order allocating 4,536 TMC is very less," the release added. Karnataka has "failed" to share with Tamil Nadu its due share of water and the quantum was 26,954 TMC, the press release said.

Excise case: Delhi HC to hear CBI plea against Kejriwal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court will on Monday hear the CBI's petition challenging a trial court order discharging AAP leaders Arvind Kejriwal, Manish Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case.

Justice Manoj Jain is also expected to take up applications by the former Delhi chief minister and his deputy seeking dismissal of the CBI's revision petition for being non-maintainable.

Kejriwal and Sisodia, who had earlier boycotted the proceedings in the case before Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma, have claimed that the plea was filed with "unprecedented haste" and in the "most unserious manner", and that they have been unable to even discern the agency's case against them in the "bare-shell" and "non-specific" petition.

"The CBI has preferred the present revision petition with unprecedented haste and in the most unserious manner. The present revision petition was filed only within four hours of passing of the order of discharge by the



Ld. Special Judge, which manifestly shows non-appreciation of the findings of the Ld. Special Judge in the discharge judgement running into more than 500 pages," the application has stated. On the last occasion, Justice Jain had granted a final opportunity to Kejriwal, Sisodia and Durgesh Pathak to respond to the CBI's plea within two weeks.

In the latest applications, Kejriwal and Sisodia have asserted that the trial court discharged all accused persons after hearing the matter in detail for more than three months, but the CBI has not pointed out any specific finding that is "perverse" or shows any irregularity. On February 27, the trial court discharged former Delhi chief minister Kejriwal, Sisodia and 21 others in the liquor policy case, ruling that it was wholly unable to survive judicial scrutiny and stood discredited in its entirety. In its revision petition, the CBI has said that the discharge order was patently illegal, perverse and suffered from errors apparent on the face.

The petition has contended that the trial court conducted a mini-trial at the stage of framing of charges and passed the discharge order on a "selective reading of the prosecution case".

Not only did the trial court fail to appreciate the facts of the case but it also passed unwarranted adverse remarks against the investigating agency and the investigating officer, the plea has claimed.

SC to hear Rahul Gandhi's assets plea on Monday



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday Congress leader Rahul Gandhi's plea challenging the Allahabad High Court order which directed the CBI and ED to verify the allegations of disproportionate assets against him.

As per the apex court's cause list of August 17, a bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana will hear the matter. Expressing dissatisfaction with the CBI's response, the Allahabad High Court's Lucknow bench on July 20 had directed the agency's senior officer to personally file a fresh affidavit detailing the progress made in the probe into the allegations of disproportionate assets against the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha.

The high court had noted that the affidavit filed by the CBI was not in compliance with its earlier order and did not adequately explain the progress made on the complaint submitted by the petitioner against Gandhi related to his assets. The court had directed the joint director or the head of the concerned zone at the CBI's Anti-Corruption headquarters in New Delhi to personally file a fresh affidavit before the next hearing, detailing the progress made in the matter.

The bench had treated the matter as part-heard and fixed August 20 as the next date of hearing. The High Court had also granted four weeks to the Union Government to file detailed counter affidavits on behalf of the Department of Personnel and Training, the Department of Revenue under the Ministry of Finance, the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, and the Serious Fraud Investigation Office. It had also directed that the entire case record continue to remain in a sealed cover in the safe custody of the senior registrar, in terms of its earlier orders.

The high court was hearing a plea that sought an investigation by the CBI and the ED into allegations of disproportionate assets against the Congress leader.

The order was passed after

India’s Heritage: From Pilgrimage to Sustainable Tourism

Heritage is more than a collection of monuments, traditions, and cultural practices inherited from the past. It is a repository of collective memory, identity, and civilisational continuity that shapes how societies understand themselves and their place in the world. Increasingly, heritage is also recognised as an economic resource. When linked with tourism, it can generate employment, stimulate local enterprise, support regional development, and create opportunities for sustainable growth.

Ancient India did not have tourism in the modern sense. There were no travel agencies, no packaged itineraries, no government schemes to promote leisure travel. What India had instead was something older and, in many ways, more sophisticated: *tirthayatra*. As noted in the Mahabharata, Anusasana Parva.

नास्ति तीर्थसमं पुण्यं नास्ति तीर्थसमं तपः।
नास्ति तीर्थसमं दानं तस्मात् तीर्थं समाश्रयेत्॥
(verse 13.108.16 from the Mahabharata (Anusasana Parva).



JUSTICE VINEET SARAN
FORMER JUDGE,
SUPREME COURT
OF INDIA



DR. SUCHI DAYAL
SENIOR RESEARCH
FELLOW,
BHARAT KI SOCH

e-Banaras allow visitors to experience cultural practices such as yoga, music, and rituals in a meaningful way. It works because it is rooted in something real-a living tradition that the city has sustained over centuries.

Recognising the economic, cultural, and social potential of such forms of heritage engagement, the Government of India has launched a number of initiatives aimed at integrating cultural preservation with tourism, infrastructure, and local livelihoods. Programmes such as PRASAD (Pilgrimage Rejuvenation and Spiritual Augmentation Drive), HRIDAY (Heritage City Development and Augmentation Yojana), and Swadesh Darshan seek not merely to improve visitor facilities but to strengthen the cultural, economic, and social ecosystems that sustain heritage destinations. Together, these initiatives reflect an increasingly integrated approach in which heritage is viewed not as a relic of the past but as a living asset capable of generating employment, supporting local enterprise, revitalising historic urban centres, and strengthening cultural identity. In many respects, these efforts represent a contemporary attempt to reconnect tourism, community welfare, and cultural continuity in ways that echo

the historical logic of *tirthayatra*.

Ancient India developed a model in which heritage, mobility, community welfare, and economic activity were interconnected; contemporary policy is seeking to revive and adapt that logic for modern development. Yet the long-term sustainability of heritage tourism ultimately depends on the communities that sustain these traditions. Temples, pilgrimage routes, festivals, traditional crafts, oral histories, and ritual practices survive only when the communities that sustain them remain economically and socially viable. In the Indian context, this principle resonates strongly with the civilisational ethos of *tirthayatra*, where sacred places were maintained through collective responsibility and sustained community engagement.

However, challenges remain. Excessive commercialisation can transform living traditions into performances staged solely for visitors, while unchecked tourist flows may strain local resources, generate waste, and erode the very cultural authenticity that attracts visitors in the first place. Cleanliness and environmental management, waste disposal, sanitation, river conservation, crowd management, and the maintenance of public spaces are not merely municipal concerns but heritage concerns. The success of heritage tourism ultimately depends upon whether local communities, religious institutions and devotees themselves regard preservation as a shared responsibility rather than a governmental obligation alone.

As reflected in the *Vishnu Purana*, the responsibility of preservation has long been recognised.

A widely cited tirtha-mahatmya verse (traditional) declares,

“पृथिव्यां यानि तीर्थानि पुण्यान्यायतनानि च।
तानि सर्वाणि रक्ष्याणि मानवैर्मूर्तिमिच्छता॥”
(All sacred places on earth must be protected by those who seek well-being and prosperity)



INDIA'S ANCIENT PILGRIMAGE TRADITIONS CAN INFORM A MODERN MODEL OF SUSTAINABLE HERITAGE TOURISM BY LINKING CULTURAL PRESERVATION, COMMUNITY OWNERSHIP, LOCAL LIVELIHOODS, RESPONSIBLE TRAVEL, AND DEVELOPMENT.



Fable with Moral

King Shibi and the Dove

(Mahabharata, Vana Parva)



King Shibi, a famously generous and just monarch of the lunar dynasty, faced a divine test of character when Dharmaraj and Indra descended to evaluate his virtue.

While the king sat on his palace terrace, a terrified dove flew into his lap, desperately seeking refuge from a chasing eagle. King Shibi had vowed to protect anyone who sought his shelter. Believing that animals and birds deserve the same protection as human beings, he promised to keep the dove safe from harm.

The eagle landed and demanded its rightful prey to appease its hunger. When Shibi offered regular meat from his kitchen, the eagle refused. Instead, the eagle agreed to free the dove on two strict conditions: Shibi must provide an equal weight of flesh cut from his own body, and not a single tear could fall from the king's eyes, as food given in distress would be unacceptable.

Shibi readily agreed and called for a balance scale. He placed the dove on one side and began cutting flesh from his own body to place on the other. Miraculously, no matter how much flesh the king added, the pan holding the

small dove always weighed heavier. As the king continued carving away nearly his entire right side, a tear finally escaped his left eye.

The eagle immediately protested, assuming the king regretted his choice. Shibi smiled and clarified that his eye wept tears of joy, grateful that the remaining half of his body could also be sacrificed to fulfill his sacred promise.

Instantly, the eagle and the dove vanished, revealing the gods Dharmaraj and Indra in their true forms. They showered the king with flowers, restored his body to health, and granted him divine boons. King Shibi ruled righteously for many years before ascending to heaven, leaving behind an eternal lesson on the absolute duty of protecting the vulnerable and the supreme value of selfless sacrifice.

Moral of the fable: Always help the helpless

UNJUMBLE

1. Unjumble these scrambled words to form the terms often used in Economy, Commerce & Finance in Ancient India:

HECTIT

NARI

KULASH

GABHA

2. Arrange the circled letters to answer the following:

A river crossing, ferry site, or inland water port for collection of transit tolls: _____



Answer: 1. Chetli, Rima, Bhaga; 2. Tirtha

Marvels of India

PUNCH-MARKED COINS



Bharat's Earliest Monetary Marvel
Punch-marked coins (*karshapanas*), circulating from roughly the 6th century BCE to the 2nd century CE, are recognised as the earliest standardised currency in the Indian subcontinent. Cut from silver (occasionally copper) sheets and stamped with symbols such as the sun, animals and trees, they emerged during the second urbanisation (the first being that of the Harappan civilisation) and the expansion of trade networks among the *Mahajanapadas*.

Facilitating Commerce
These coins marked the shift from barter to a currency-based economy, with denominations such as *pana*, *ardha-pana*, *masaka* and *kakini* attested in literary sources including Kautilya's *Arthashastra* and Panini's *Ashtadhyayi*. Archaeological hoards spanning present-day Bharat, Pakistan, Afghanistan, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh reveal their wide circulation, integrating regional markets into interconnected trade circuits and routes.

State Finance and Metallurgy
Under the Mauryas, minting shifted from merchant guilds toward centralised authority, supporting taxation and administration. Scientific analysis of coin hoards confirms silver as the predominant metal, alongside copper, lead and trace amounts of gold. At the same time, later series unravel progressive silver decrease, reflecting political transitions. The punch-marked coins constitute physical evidence of Bharat's fiscal history as a leading economic power and a global economic force to reckon with.

QUIZ

Economy, Commerce & Finance

Questions	Option A	Option B	Option C	Option D
1. The people from the Indus Valley Civilisation used a highly standardised system of weights made of a specific type of stone for trade and commerce. What is the name of this stone?	Lapis Lazuli	Carnelian	Chert	Steatite
2. Which ancient overland highway connected Pataliputra through Taxila to Central Asian branches of the main Silk Road?	Uttarapatha	Dakshinapatha	Vyapar Marg	Rajamarg
3. Which ancient Indian dynasty's rulers were officially called as "Dakshinapathapati" due to their control over the critical southern trade highway?	Mauryan	Satavahana	Chola	Chalukya
4. Which dynasty is credited with being the first to exercise significant control over the 'Great Silk Route' branch passing through Central Asia to India, facilitating a massive gold influx?	Mauryan	Saka	Kushana	Gupta

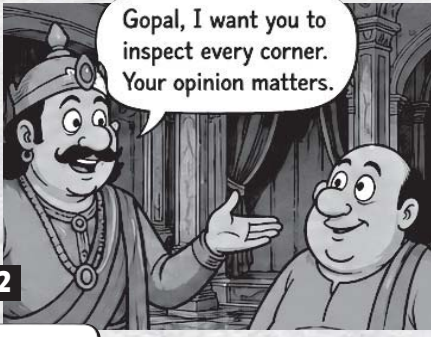
Answers: 1 - C, 2 - A, 3 - B, 4 - C

nitikatha

The King's New Palace

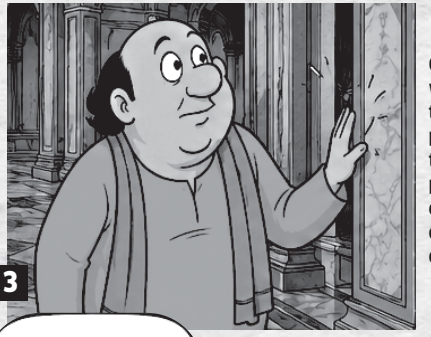


1. The King was proud. His new palace was magnificent - tall towers, wide halls, and glittering marble floors.



2. The King showed it off to everyone... and asked Gopal to inspect it as well.

Gopal, I want you to inspect every corner. Your opinion matters.



3. Gopal wandered through the palace, tapping walls, peering into corners, and checking every detail.



4. Finally, he stopped at a grand staircase.

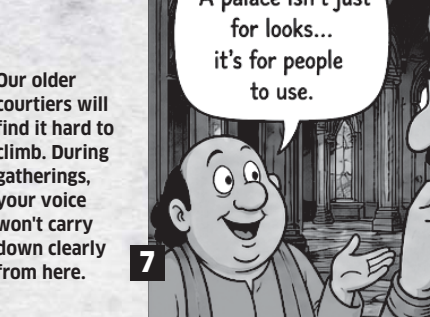


5. "Majesty, you may need to rebuild this step."



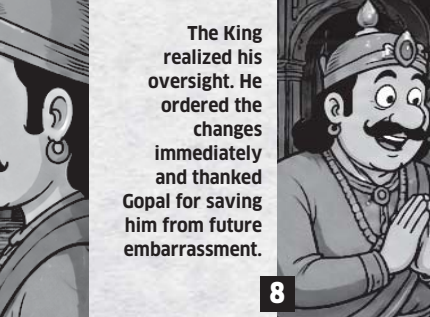
6. Why? What is wrong with it?

The staircase is too steep.



7. Our older courtyards will find it hard to climb. During gatherings, your voice won't carry down clearly from here.

A palace isn't just for looks... it's for people to use.



8. The King realized his oversight. He ordered the changes immediately and thanked Gopal for saving him from future embarrassment.

Well said, Gopal! You have once again opened my eyes.

TRUE WISDOM SEES BEYOND BEAUTY AND THINKS OF PEOPLE.

FROM THE WORLD

HUNGARY

Bus crash kills 12 people

A passenger bus travelling on a highway in Hungary early Sunday went off the road and into a ditch where it overturned, killing 12 and injuring others, police said.

The bus, which was carrying a group of Polish tourists, was travelling in the eastbound lanes near the town of Mezokeresztes when it overturned on the M3 motorway around 140 kilometres east of Hungary's Capital, Budapest, at around 1 am on Sunday. Police said it was likely that the driver fell asleep, causing the accident, and that the driver had been taken into custody. Hungary's National Directorate for Disaster Management said that 57 passengers and two drivers were travelling on the bus at the time of the accident, and that several of the passengers had been trapped under the vehicle when it overturned. (AP)

PAKISTAN

Two civilians shot dead

Two women of a Sindh family were shot dead in a terror attack while security forces killed seven terrorists in two separate incidents in the restive Balochistan province of Pakistan, officials said on Sunday.

The terrorists were killed in the Kharan district of the province during an operation while several other terrorists were injured, according to the Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR), the military's media wing.

The operation was conducted in the Laje area of Kharan on Saturday night following reports of terrorists' presence, the ISPR said, adding that seven terrorists belonging to Fitna al-Khwarij were killed in the operation.

Khawarij is a term that the state uses for banned organisations.

This round of security operations in Balochistan began following a deadly attack on a police check post at the Mangi Dam pumping station in Ziarat on July 6. (PTI)

Massive Ukrainian drone attack kills 6 in Russia

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Moscow

Ukraine launched hundreds of drones across Russia on Sunday, killing at least six people in one of Kyiv's largest aerial attacks of the war.

Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities. It has also increasingly pummelled giant Wildberries depots, burning billions of dollars' worth of merchandise belonging to the Russian online retail giant. Those attacks have brought the war home to the Russian public nearly 4½ years into Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Meanwhile, Ukraine also came under Russian attack, with drone strikes destroying homes and torching Kyiv's landmark book market.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said it had destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones overnight. Some 600 drones were detected headed

toward the Russian capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said, with a third of those destroyed over the Moscow region itself.

An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local Gov Andrey Vorobyov said. He also confirmed that a Ukrainian attack had sparked a blaze at a Wildberries warehouse in the town of Podolsk.

A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia's southwestern Rostov region, killing five people, local Gov. Yuri Slyusar said. The attack, with more than 150 drones, damaged several homes and a railway station and sparked a forest fire.

Russian missile attack on Ukraine's Kryvyi Rih killed two people and wounded 14 others, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on social media Sunday. He also said that one more person had been killed in the city of Sumy.

ArcelorMittal Kryvyi Rih,



Ukraine's largest steel producer, confirmed that one of its sites had been hit in a missile attack and that operations had been partially suspended.

Elsewhere, a man and a woman died when their home was hit by a Russian strike in Ukraine's southern Zaporizhzhia region, said Ivan Fedorov, the head of the local military administration.

Russian attacks also sparked fires throughout the Ukrainian capital, Kyiv, wounding six people. A blaze took hold at one of the

city's largest book markets, tearing through the kiosks huddled close to the Pochaina metro station. Firefighters fought back the flames, which sent plumes of black smoke across the Capital, and picked their way through rubble where the market's crowded pavilions once stood.

"Wherever the Russians can reach with their ballistic missiles, they strike civilian infrastructure," Zelenskyy said.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said Sunday that it had targeted a

metallurgical plant in Kryvyi Rih and several military-industrial sites in Kyiv, including a manufacturing facility for Ukraine's Flamingo missiles.

The domestically produced missiles are increasingly key to Ukraine's long-range attacks on Russia, with Zelenskyy announcing Saturday that Kyiv had used the weapons to attack a rocket research and production centre in Samara approximately 900 km (560 miles) from the Ukrainian border.

Romania's Ministry of National Defence said Sunday that a Spanish Air and Space Force F-18 fighter jet shot down a drone that had entered Romanian airspace.

The drone's entry into the NATO member's airspace was detected by surveillance systems at 4:44 am, the ministry said, about 24 km (14.9 miles) north of the eastern city of Galati near the border with neighbouring Moldova. Moldova is a landlocked country between Ukraine and Romania.

A Spanish F-18 aircraft that was performing air policing duties

"made radar contact with the target and received engagement approval," the ministry said. "The drone was safely shot down by the F-18 aircraft at 05:01."

The ministry later said that drone debris was also reported in the Black Sea around 10 am on Sunday, about 1.5 km from the coastal city of Constanta.

Officials did not specify the drone's origin.

The incident comes weeks after Romanian pilots shot down three drones over three days as Russia intensified attacks against Ukraine near the border. Since Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, Romania has reported dozens of drone incidents, including some that have crashed and exploded on its territory.

Acting Foreign Minister Oana Toiu said in a post on X that the Spanish deployment in Romania was scaled up "at the request of Romania and NATO to bolster the Eastern Flank following prior drone incidents," and that it was Spain's fourth such deployment.

Rescuers dig through rubble, landslides after Indonesia earthquake kills 51

FIRDIA LISNAWATI
■ Ruteng (Indonesia)

Rescue teams in eastern Indonesia recovered four more bodies Sunday after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake struck the day before, bringing the death toll to 51, authorities said. Thousands have been displaced.

The US Geological Survey said the powerful earthquake hit eastern Indonesia's Flores region at a depth of 10 kilometres (6 miles) at 5:58 am local time. Residents fled in panic as tsunami warnings were issued and later lifted. At least 235 aftershocks followed, according to Indonesia's meteorological agency.

Rescuers on Sunday dug through debris looking for people feared buried beneath landslides triggered by the quake across six regencies on Flores, a predominantly Catholic island in Muslim-majority Indonesia. They focused on three regencies that remained inaccessible after the earthquake: the hardest-hit Manggarai, East Manggarai and Nagekeo.

"We have cleared most landslides and reopened roads to previously isolated villages, although communication disruptions and power outages continue to hamper search efforts," said Fathur Rahman, head of the Search and Rescue Office in Maumere,



the Capital of Sikka regency.

The National Search and Rescue Agency said 101 people were injured. More than 900 homes were destroyed and 450 more damaged, forcing about 5,000 people into temporary shelters.

Thousands at Labuan Bajo, the gateway to Komodo National Park, one of Indonesia's best-known tourist destinations, spent the night outdoors, fearing strong aftershocks.

"The shaking was terrifying, so intense that my house nearly collapsed," said Anastasia Imad, a farmer, speaking from a makeshift green tent beside her damaged home. "We feared the aftershocks would bring it down on us while we slept."

Landslides blocked sections of the Trans-Flores Highway, a roughly 700-kilometre (435-mile) road linking

communities across the mountainous island.

Meanwhile, relief workers distributed rice, ready-to-eat meals, drinking water, blankets and medicine, while emergency shelters were being set up for displaced residents. Authorities said restoring electricity and communications, as well as delivering aid to remote villages isolated by landslides, remained among the biggest challenges.

Indonesia, an archipelago of more than 17,000 islands, is prone to earthquakes and volcanic eruptions because of its location on the Pacific "Ring of Fire," a horseshoe-shaped arc of seismic faults and volcanoes.

Flores has experienced some of the country's deadliest disasters. A powerful earthquake and tsunami in 1992 killed about 2,500 people on the island. (AP)

UK PM Andy Burnham steps up farmer funds amid extreme heat and drought conditions

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

Farmers across England will receive a 65 million pounds funding boost to help manage the impact of prolonged heatwave conditions and dry weather, British Prime Minister Andy Burnham has said.

The UK Government has been struggling to cope with an extended period of high temperatures and ongoing drought conditions across large parts of the country.

Burnham chaired an emergency ministerial Cabinet Office Briefing Room A (COBRA) on extreme heat, wildfires and drought earlier this week. After meeting farmers impacted by low yields and even lost harvests, he pledged additional support on Saturday.

"This is the third drought in five years. Farmers are at the sharp end of a changing climate, and they should not be carrying that risk alone," said Burnham.

"Lower income, higher costs, and no rain in the forecast. I understand the worry that comes with that. The ability to grow our own food is national security, and I will treat it that way," he said.

"So we are acting now: more money into farm support, help to get reservoirs built, and easier access



to water when it is scarce," said the prime minister.

As wildfires raged across the West Midlands region of England, Burnham authorised emergency text alerts on mobile phones to caution against using disposable barbecues and other fire hazards.

He was forced to defend the use of a nationwide alert system designed for extreme risk-to-life situations by warning that "Britain was a tinderbox" with multiple fires "smouldering the country".

Plans were drawn up for the use of firefighting planes to help douse flames and combat the spread of wildfires, as used across Europe and the US.

"I am acutely aware of the pressures exceptionally dry weather is placing on farm businesses," said UK Environment Secretary

Angela Eagle. "Our farmers are facing some of the toughest conditions in decades, which is why we're stepping in with practical support to help them through these challenging conditions and build resilience for the future," she said.

The package of measures unveiled this weekend includes an extra 50 million pounds for the Sustainable Farming Incentive 2026, taking the total budget to 290 million pounds, and up to 15 million pounds for on-farm reservoirs to help farmers store water.

An updated National Planning Policy Framework to be published on Monday will set out action to make it easier to build reservoirs and improve access to water during persistent drought conditions.

Downing Street said that

while immediate action is being taken, the Government is focussed on the need to adapt to a changing climate.

"The UK has a resilient food system, and the dry weather is not expected to affect national food security. But the Government is taking action now to strengthen that resilience further, through the Farming Roadmap, stronger food supply chains and its work with the National Drought Group and Farming and Food Partnership Board," Downing Street stated.

The development of nine new reservoirs to strengthen the country's water infrastructure and improve resilience to future droughts, floods and extreme weather and an investment of around 100 million pounds to strengthen the country's response to wildfires and extreme weather are among some of the planned actions.

This week marked the UK's fifth heatwave of the summer, with temperatures hitting 38 degrees Celsius in some parts.

Network Rail admitted "exceptional challenges" for the transport network after two trains derailed in less than 24 hours. While temperatures are set to come down in the coming days, the forecast for much-needed rain remains less certain. (PTI)

Nepal helps Bhutan strengthen earthquake preparedness

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu/Thimphu

A full-scale earthquake simulation in Bhutan's Capital has exposed gaps in emergency equipment and resource mobilisation while testing how authorities, hospitals and emergency responders would coordinate after a major quake, with Nepal's earthquake experts providing technical support for the exercise.

The simulation recreated a scenario akin to a magnitude 7.5 earthquake in Thimphu, which involved mass casualties, damaged buildings, disrupted roads and power supply, and tested how authorities would make decisions, communicate, coordinate rescue operations and mobilise resources in the aftermath of such a disaster.

The National Society for Earthquake Technology-Nepal (NSET), with support from the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) and Bhutanese authorities, designed and facilitated the full-scale simulation exercise on June 23 as part of efforts to strengthen the Thimphu Earthquake Contingency Plan. Findings of the exercise were published by a Nepali weekly on Saturday.

CDRI was conceptualised by India and launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi at the United Nations Climate Action Summit in New York in 2019 to promote



the resilience of infrastructure systems to climate and disaster risks.

It has more than 50 member countries, which include India, Nepal, Bhutan, Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Germany, Italy, the US, the UK, Sri Lanka and the Netherlands. It also brings together bodies like the World Bank, Asian Development Bank, United Nations Development Programme and European Union.

The exercise in Thimphu followed a tabletop simulation and aimed to test the contingency arrangements in a field setting, according to the State-run Bhutan Broadcasting Service (BBS) and the Nepali Times weekly newspaper.

Bhutan and Nepal lie in the seismically active Himalayan region and are vulnerable to major earthquakes. Bhutan was hit by a magnitude 5.5 earthquake on June 7, while a magnitude 5 earthquake struck Rukum East in western Nepal on July 19.

Bhutan's deadliest record-

ed earthquake was an estimated magnitude 8.5 quake in 1714. In Nepal, more than 9,000 people were killed when a magnitude 7.8 earthquake struck in April 2015, followed by powerful aftershocks, including a magnitude 7.3 quake the following month. During the full-scale exercise, Bhutanese authorities created a mass-casualty scenario involving the country's largest referral hospital and two primary healthcare centres, Nepali Times reported.

The scenario assumed that some emergency medical staff could not reach the hospital because of family emergencies or blocked roads, while the hospitals themselves were without power.

BBS reported that the exercise involved response operations at nine locations in Thimphu, including a simulated hotel collapse, severely damaged residential buildings and a fire in Olakha - a prominent urban area and commercial zone in the Capital city.

US top West Asia commander visits deployed aircraft carrier

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Dubai

Admiral Brad Cooper, the top US military commander in the West Asia, visited the USS Lincoln in the Arabian Sea during a 10-day tour in the region that concluded on Saturday, US Central Command said.

Israel said its strikes in southern Lebanon, which killed at least 11 people, targeted two Hezbollah commanders. And a Hamas delegation is in Cairo on Sunday for Gaza ceasefire-related talks with Egyptian officials.

Admiral Cooper visited



Admiral Brad Cooper

the USS Lincoln in the Arabian Sea as reports have emerged of mental health and supply issues aboard the long-deployed aircraft carrier. The Lincoln arrived in

the West Asia in January and has been supporting the US war against Iran, including the blockade on Iranian ports. Its deployment has included a record-setting uninterrupted time at sea of more than 240 days.

Extended deployments of carriers, which can have more than 5,000 sailors and Marines on board, have raised concerns about the impact not only on the ships but on service members.

"History will record this deployment as one of the most operationally intense and consequential of the modern era," Cooper said of

the Lincoln strike group in a statement released Saturday.

Cooper also went to Bahrain, Iraq, Israel, Jordan, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates to meet with civilian and military leaders, according to the Central Command statement.

The US Navy's blockade was in response to Iran's asserting control over the Strait of Hormuz after the war started on February 28 with US and Israeli strikes. About one-fifth of the world's traded oil and natural gas passed through the waterway at the mouth of the Persian Gulf before then.

Bangladesh could have avoided power crisis with more renewables: Experts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

Experts have called for a boost in investment in renewable energy, pointing out that the current power crisis in Bangladesh, which has disrupted daily life and businesses, could have been avoided had the country invested in the RE sector sooner.

The renewable energy (RE) capacity of Bangladesh stands at nearly 6 per cent of its total power generation as of 2026.

The country had already been facing an energy crisis, and the situation had now been compounded by an accident at an LNG terminal and adverse weather (in the



Bay of Bengal), newspaper Ajker Patrika quoted State Minister for Power, Energy and Mineral Resources Anindya Islam Amit as saying on August 13.

The acute shortage of liquefied natural gas (LNG)

has disrupted electricity generation across the nation, prompting the government to also approach India for assistance.

Speaking to PTI Videos, Shahriar Ahmed Chowdhury, Director of the Centre for

Energy Research at the United International University in Dhaka, said that while the current government has taken measures to encourage renewable energy, more investment is needed to increase the country's RE share.

It can also help ease the crisis and reduce pressure on imports of fossil fuels, he said. Bangladesh's NDC 3.0 (national action plan to reduce heat-trapping gases to combat climate change) includes a target to achieve 25 per cent of total power mix from renewable energy sources by 2035, enhancing energy efficiency by 19.2 per cent, and transitioning away from fossil fuels in energy systems.

Firefighters battle massive Belgian wildfire, forcing hundreds to evacuate

SYLVIE CORBET/
AHMAD SEIR NASSIRI
■ Baelen (Belgium)

Firefighters battled a massive wildfire in Belgium on Sunday that has burned over 27 square kilometres in the High Fens, the country's largest reserve, forcing nearby residents to evacuate in what media describe as one of the worst-ever wildfires in the country's recent history.

About 600 residents in nearby municipalities in Waimes and Butgenbach, in Liege province near the German border, were told to evacuate on August 15 as winds shifted and smoke spread through the area.

Authorities also advised tourists to leave, while a nearby gymnasium was opened to receive evacuees.

Liege provincial Governor Herve Jamar, in a statement, said that more than 250 emergency personnel have been deployed, including over 100 Belgian and German firefighters, police and military officers and civil protection staff, helped by firefighting helicopters. (AP)



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BUSINESS13

Zeus’s rule of law in Nolan’s *The Odyssey*

LEKHA CHAKRABORTY

In Christopher Nolan’s *The Odyssey*, a king returns from a long war to his hometown Ithaca to find his palace consumed by free-riders. Along the way, gods and monsters demand their price. Columbia University professor Adam Tooze quote-tweeted Nolan’s film as a commentary on a world “where rules have collapsed.” It is a powerful reading. When reciprocity weakens, cooperation becomes fragile. Enforcement eventually returns to its most primitive form—force.

The story is three thousand years old. Yet Nolan makes it feel contemporary. At its centre is Zeus’s law—the film’s condensed version of *xenia*, the ancient Greek obligation of hospitality between host and guest. Treat the stranger as you would wish to be treated. A traveller may even be a god in disguise. Hospitality, then, is not merely kindness. It is an institution.

Economists would recognise the logic immediately. Zeus’s law lowers the cost of dealing with strangers when contracts are incomplete, and enforcement is weak. It creates trust, facilitates exchange and lengthens the

shadow of the future. Strangers become potential partners rather than immediate threats. Civilisation begins with that expectation that vulnerability will not be exploited.

The Trojan Horse as Institutional Rupture

Nolan turns the Trojan Horse from military cunning into institutional betrayal. After ten years of war, the Greeks leave a wooden horse outside Troy as an apparent offering to Athena. The Trojans accept it and bring it inside. Hidden soldiers emerge at night, open the gates and destroy the city.

In Homer, it is strategic deception. In Nolan, the deeper violence is the corruption of trust itself. The gift—the instrument of peaceful exchange—becomes an instrument of predation. Trust becomes the weapon. This changes Odysseus. He is less the celebrated strategist and more a man haunted by his own ingenuity. Guilt replaces cunning.

The gods, too, recede. They become less characters than elemental forces—fear, desire, guilt, fate. Odysseus’s island sojourns become tangible manifestations of these transient forces.

The same institutional logic returns in Ithaca. Telemachus cannot simply remove the suitors consuming his household’s resources. Property rights are uncertain. Enforcement is weak. The household becomes an open-access resource.

The suitors free-ride. Penelope’s endless weaving is a private response to institutional failure. She buys time while guarding the “empty throne” of Ithaca, waiting for Odysseus’s return.

The massacre that follows is therefore not merely revenge. It is the violent restoration of authority after informal rules have failed. Force becomes the residual institution. This is where the ancient story becomes political economy. Openness of households, cities or economies creates gains from exchange and specialisation only when supported by credible reciprocity. When reciprocity weakens, risk rises, monitoring becomes costly and time horizons contract. Trust retreats. So does exchange.

Modern markets are built on these invisible institutions. Trade, migration and global supply chains cannot be governed entirely through contracts. They depend on economics of trust. When such expectations collapse, the economics changes to higher risk premia. That is perhaps Nolan’s most contemporary insight. Emily Wilson, however, is unhappy about his deviations from the classic. Her translation of the epic was Nolan’s inspiration to take this movie, though.

The *Odyssey* is not only a story about a man trying to return home. It is a story about what happens when the rules that make cooperation possible disappear. Societies rarely notice institu-

tions when they work. They notice them when they fail. And when reciprocity is exhausted, and powerful leaders’ instincts run the global order, violence becomes the norm. Civilisation dies off. This is resonating in contemporary times of geopolitical uncertainties and wars.

Nolan has taken a three-thousand-year-old poem and made its oldest institution speak to the political economy of our time. That is no small achievement.

Yet at the heart of this entire drama is the “complicated man”, Odysseus. He returns to his wife, but return does not restore what was lost. After violence, deception and years of wandering, he leaves Ithaca once more, “chasing the escaping sun”, to honour the dead, leaving the kingdom to his son.

There is an economics here that is not about accumulation, but about irredeemable debts. Some debts cannot be settled by return. Some losses cannot be compensated by victory. The past carries a value that no present exchange can extinguish. Perhaps this inner haunting is the metaphysics of economics: that what matters most cannot always be repaid. In the end, perhaps the only solace left to the living is to remember and honour the dead.

Author is an economist and a professor, NIPFP and Research Affiliate of Levy Economics Institute of Bard College, New York and Member, Governing Board of International Institute of Public Finance (IIPF) Munich

6 food companies rectified misleading claims, says FSSAI

Food regulator FSSAI on Sunday said six companies have taken corrective actions like withdrawal of misleading labels and trade marks, following the notices issued to these companies for violations of law.

In a social media post, the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) informed that six Food Business Operators (FBOs) have taken prompt corrective actions following notices from the regulator.

“Measures range from withdrawing misleading label claims to revising product packaging to ensure consumer safety and compliance,” it added.

Giving details, the FSSAI said Livyor Ventures Pvt Ltd has withdrawn the misleading claim of ‘vegan & healthy’.

The company has submitted its reply with reference to regarding the misleading claims made on the label of the product “Livor Roasted Edamame Beans”.

In its reply, the FBO has stated that the claims “vegan” and “healthy” were inadvertently printed on the product label due to a lack of awareness of the applicable regulatory requirements.

“The FBO has expressed regret for the lapse, apologised for the violation, and assured that such non-compliance will not be repeated in the future,” the regulator said.

Further, the FBO has informed that it has initiated the process of revising the product labels. The company is destroying the existing packaging material bearing the non-compliant claims to ensure that it is not used in the future. Similarly, Honest Innovations For You Pvt Ltd and Heliostone Specialities Pvt Ltd have changed their misleading trade mark.

(PTI)

Navi Mumbai airport welcomes first foreign freighter cargo

Adani Group-CIDCO jointly owned Navi Mumbai International Airport (NMIA) on Sunday announced the first arrival of an international freighter at its facility, with the first Hong Kong Air cargo-operated aircraft arriving from Hong Kong.

The development is a part of NMIA’s wider international cargo ramp-up, with 13 new freighter services expected to commence operations, the private airport operator said.

Hong Kong Air Cargo will operate three weekly services between Hong Kong and Navi Mumbai, translating into six weekly cargo air traffic movements, Navi Mumbai International Ltd (NMIAL) – the entity managing the airport – said.

(PTI)

ONGC gets US licence to resume full Venezuela operations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corp (ONGC) has secured a licence from the US Treasury’s Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC), allowing it to resume full operations in Venezuela after years of limited activity because of sanctions-related risks, a senior company official said.

The US approval removes a key hurdle for ONGC’s Venezuelan investments and could pave the way for the State-run explorer to expand production, sign new agreements and take over operatorship of some projects from Venezuela’s State oil company PDVSA, Anupam Agarwal, director-finance at ONGC, said at an investor call after the first-quarter earnings announcement.

“Now we have full freedom to work on the Venezuela project because earlier we were restricting our operations there because of the sanction-related risks. Those risks are behind us,” Agarwal said.

ONGC Videsh Ltd, the company’s overseas investment arm, holds a 40 per cent interest in the San Cristobal oil project, while the remaining is with

Venezuela’s Petroleos de Venezuela SA (PDVSA).

It holds another 11 per cent stake in the Carabobo project, which is under development.

An OFAC license would enable the company to manage the finances of its Venezuelan projects and help it recover a pending dividend of more than \$500 million.

ONGC is already in talks with Venezuelan authorities and its joint-venture partners over its interests in two projects — San Cristobal and Carabobo — and expects positive developments soon, including new agreements and a possible transfer of operatorship from PDVSA, he said.

The licence is significant for ONGC because US sanctions on Venezuela’s oil sector have for years complicated financial transactions, investment and operations involv-

ing Venezuelan crude and energy assets. The company had therefore curtailed activity despite its longstanding presence in the country.

The company can now invest in projects to raise oil production. San Cristobal produced around 0.265 million tonnes of oil equivalent in FY26. This is a 10th of the production potential, and the OFAC license means it can invest in raising output.

Venezuela is strategically important for ONGC because it holds the world’s largest proven crude oil reserves, estimated by OPEC at about 303 billion barrels, more than Saudi Arabia. Much of the country’s production potential remains constrained by years of underinvestment, sanctions and operational difficulties, leaving substantial scope for additional development.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

former chairman of the Council for Leather Exports (CLE) Aqeel Panaruna said that with progressive trade pacts and foreign trade policy opening new opportunities, India is firmly positioned for sustained growth and prosperity.

“We remain committed to strengthening Indian manufacturing, generating large-scale employment and contributing meaningfully to the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047,” Panaruna said.

He said that the prime minister’s emphasis on self-reliance, innovation, youth empowerment, employment generation and global competitiveness has further strengthened the collective resolve of the industry.

Sharing similar views, Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) Director

General Ajay Sahai said the prime minister’s call to MSMEs to fully leverage India’s growing network of FTAs is both timely and significant.

“FTAs are not merely about tariff concessions; they provide MSMEs a gateway to integrate with global value chains, access larger markets and enhance their competitiveness. With preferential market access now available across several major economies, the real opportunity lies in converting these agreements into export orders,” Sahai said.

FIEO will continue to work closely with MSMEs to build awareness on rules of origin, standards and market opportunities so that even smaller enterprises can confidently take Indian products and brands to global markets.

Set up task force to fill 38 DIPAM vacancies: Panel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Standing Committee on Finance has flagged the “crippling” 43 per cent vacancy in the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM), and recommended setting up a task force to ensure the early filling of all 38 vacant positions.

Lamenting that “no tangible progress” has been made in resolving vacancies at DIPAM since the Committee’s report presented in March, the panel said, “for a department overseeing a public asset portfolio exceeding

₹42.76 lakh crore, routine administrative correspondence is grossly inadequate”.

The Standing Committee, in its report tabled in Parliament in March, had noted that maintaining only 51 officers against a sanctioned strength of 89 - with critical shortages at the Director (11 vacancies) and Under Secretary (8 vacancies) levels - “severely jeopardises” the department’s ability to execute complex transactions like the IDBI Bank sale or finalise CPSE MoUs.

Such significant manpower shortages in a field requiring highly specialised financial and legal expertise

undermine the department’s capacity to effectively manage the disinvestment target and the recycling of prime real estate assets, it had noted.

In their “action-taken” reply, the finance ministry said that DIPAM has been pursuing the matter with the

concerned departments on priority and that the matter of filling up vacancies of ASOs (Assistant Section Officer), SOs (Section Officer), Under Secretaries, and Assistant Directors was taken up with the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT),

Services Ltd, said. On the domestic front, gold futures for October delivery climbed ₹2,686, or nearly 2 per cent, last week to close at ₹1.54 lakh per 10 grams on the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX). MCX silver for September contract gained ₹4,458, or 1.9 per cent, to ₹2.35 lakh per kilogram.

“Gold traded higher this week, gaining 1 per cent, while the rally extended more than 2 per cent at the peak before profit-booking emerged at higher levels,”

Department of Expenditure, and Department of Economic Affairs.

The Committee viewed with deep concern that DIPAM, despite overseeing an ambitious value maximisation agenda, has been allocated a modest budget of ₹55.92 crore and is operating with a “crippling 43 per cent vacancy rate”.

“The Committee, therefore, urge the Ministry of Finance to pursue the matter on priority through a dedicated inter-departmental task force with DoPT and DoE to ensure early filling up of all 38 vacant positions,” the report said.

said Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst — Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities.

MCX gold has gained nearly 9.5 per cent in August, making consolidation and intermittent profit-booking at higher levels more likely in the near term, he said.

In the international markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery rose \$37.6, or nearly 1 per cent, last week to \$4,437.3 per ounce. Silver went up \$1.61, or 2.5 per cent, to \$65.11 an ounce in New York.

PROSPECT



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma chaired a review meeting on Assam Houses and Bhawans across the country, directing officials to expedite ongoing works, ensure quality through regular inspections and resolve pending issues on priority.

Annamrita Foundation strengthens school nutrition under PM POSHAN initiative

A nutritious meal helps children stay focused, participate actively in school and support their overall development. Recognising the link between nutrition and education, the Annamrita Foundation is strengthening school nutrition under the Government of India's PM POSHAN initiative.

The Foundation provides freshly prepared, hygienic and nutritious meals to children in government schools, ensuring quality and timely delivery. In Haryana, it operates a large network across Gurugram, Faridabad, Palwal and Kurukshetra, serving approximately 2.87 lakh students daily in 1,956 schools. This includes around 1,00,999 students in Gurugram, 90,503 in Faridabad, 52,070 in Palwal and 43,601 in Kurukshetra.



UPSIDA CEO inspects development works at perfume park in Kannauj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Lucknow

Under the leadership of the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh, Yogi Adityanath, the Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA) is continuously working towards strengthening and expanding industrial infrastructure across the State. The Authority is making a significant contribution towards achieving the goal of making Uttar Pradesh a 1 trillion economy.

In continuation of these efforts, Dr Balkar Singh, Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of the Uttar Pradesh State Industrial Development Authority (UPSIDA), visited the Industrial Area Perfume Park located in Kannauj district and conducted an on-site inspection of the ongoing development works and available infrastructure facilities. During the visit, necessary directions were issued to the concerned officials regarding the overall development of Perfume Park, improved connectivity, and provision of essential facilities to entrepreneurs.



The Chief Executive Officer directed the concerned officials to ensure connectivity of Perfume Park with the Agra-Lucknow Expressway by establishing effective coordination with UPEIDA and taking the necessary action on priority. He instructed that the required proposals be prepared and further action be expedited to develop smooth transportation and better connectivity for the industrial area.

During the visit, directions were also issued to examine, as per applicable rules, the provision of a petrol pump, hotel, and other essential commercial and civic amenities for the convenience of entrepreneurs, investors, and visitors in the industrial area.

The Chief Executive Officer directed the concerned officials to prepare a comprehensive roadmap and take time-bound action for the planned development of these facilities.

The Chief Executive Officer directed the Regional Manager, Kanpur, to examine on priority the issues and pending matters related to the allotment of plots in Perfume Park and ensure their immediate and time-bound resolution so that entrepreneurs and investors do not face any difficulties.

In addition, all concerned

officials were directed to establish effective coordination with the district administration and concerned departments/agencies and take expeditious action to ensure the availability of gas supply and other essential basic and infrastructure facilities in the industrial area.

Chief Executive Officer Dr Balkar Singh stated that UPSIDA is continuously working towards promoting industrial investment in the State and providing a conducive environment for industries. Effective operation of basic infrastructure facilities in industrial areas, time-bound resolution of entrepreneurs' issues, and regular dialogue with the industry are among the Authority's key priorities.

He directed the concerned officials to ensure the time-bound and effective resolution of issues and suggestions received from industrial units after examining them in accordance with the applicable rules. He further directed that necessary action be taken on priority to maintain high standards of infrastructure facilities in industrial areas.

Pijush Hazarika attends 79th Foundation Day of College of Agriculture, AAU Jorhat

TONY DAS ■ GUWAHATI

Minister for Agriculture Pijush Hazarika on Sunday attended the 79th Foundation Day celebrations of the College of Agriculture, Assam Agricultural University (AAU), Jorhat, as the Chief Guest.

Addressing the students, the Minister stated that it is not feasible for the government sector to provide jobs to all agriculture graduates. Therefore, students should not rely solely on government jobs but break away from conventional mindsets to establish themselves as successful farmers and agripreneurs. He added that the youth can earn significantly more through horticulture than in a typical government job. He further emphasised that genuine growth in the agriculture sector remains impossible until society dispels the perception that farming is meant only for the economically disadvantaged.

Highlighting that the Agriculture Department has decided to conduct agricultural workshops across 50 colleges in the state as per the directions of Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma,



Minister Hazarika requested the university authorities and faculty members to extend their full cooperation. He shared that a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) will soon be signed between the Education Department and the Agriculture Department to implement this initiative smoothly.

Furthermore, noting that the Agriculture Department will distribute 5 crore high-value fruit saplings across the state, the Minister sought the

active cooperation of Assam Agricultural University to support the farmers. He also urged the students to take the lead in popularising Makhana cultivation, noting that it can help farmers double their income without facing the typical challenges associated with traditional crops.

Reaffirming the government's commitment to achieving the Chief Minister's vision of turning Assam into a leading agricultural state, the Minister revealed that the Agriculture Department is rapidly supplying paddy seedlings and horticulture saplings to four recent flood-affected districts.

The event was attended by Vice-Chancellor of Assam Agricultural University Dr Dipjyoti Rajkhowa, Vice-Chancellor of Madhabdev University Arupjyoti Choudhury, MP Kamakhya Prasad Tasa, MLAs Hitendra Nath Goswami, Rupjyoti Kurni and Dhiraj Gowala, alongside several other distinguished dignitaries.

Following the event, the Minister inspected the AAU campus to review various ongoing agricultural research and demonstration projects.

NBCC celebrates 80th I-Day with patriotic fervour



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited celebrated the 80th Independence Day with patriotic fervour at NBCC Bhawan, Lodhi Road, New Delhi, reaffirming its commitment to nation-building and the vision of a Viksit Bharat.

The Independence Day celebrations commenced with the hoisting of the National Flag, followed by the National Anthem and National Song, in the presence of Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, Chairman & Managing Director, NBCC, Functional Directors, Chief Vigilance Officer, senior officers, and employees.

Speaking on the occasion, Dr KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, NBCC, reiterated NBCC's commitment to the

vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, highlighting landmark initiatives such as the Amrapali projects, East Kidwai Nagar redevelopment, New Moti Bagh and the World Trade Center, New Delhi.

He appreciated the dedication of NBCC employees and encouraged them to embrace greater innovation, technology and new-age solutions to further strengthen the organisation's contribution to nation-building.

The festivities followed a special cultural programme organised by the UMANG Cultural Committee on the eve of Independence Day, during which the Official NBCC Anthem was introduced. The employee-driven initiative reflects the spirit of unity, pride, patriotism and collective identity of NBCCians.

Indian Bank plans to garner \$400 m via ECB this week, says MD Binod Kumar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
Chennai

To cash in on the RBI's concessional swap window, Indian Bank plans to raise \$400 million through External Commercial Borrowings (ECB) this week to support its business growth. In addition, the public sector lender may mop up another \$600 million via ECB before the Reserve Bank of India's deadline of December 31, 2026.

"The bank is considering raising \$400 million via the ECB route as early as this week...the overseas fund raise would come at a very competitive rate," Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told PTI in an interview. Post August, he said, the bank would consider garnering another \$600 million as the RBI window is available till the end of the calendar year.

Overall, the bank is planning to garner \$1 billion from the ECB and about \$2 billion via Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) or FCNR (B) deposits, he said.

"Indian Bank has already raised \$1.5 billion from



FCNR(B) deposits... we have seen good demand from NRIs. They are willing to put their money in such a product as it provides attractive returns... we hope it would touch \$2 billion," he said.

Better than expected FCNR(B) flows have been there, which is why the RBI halted the concessional swap facility much ahead of the scheduled deadline of September 30, 2026, he said.

On Friday, the Reserve Bank prematurely closed the window for mobilising FCNR(B) deposits under its special USD-INR forex swap facility citing the encouraging response and strong forex inflows generated through the scheme.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (15.8.26)

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

MONDAY | AUGUST 17, 2026

ACROSS

DOWN

SOLUTION (15.8.26)

Punjab & Sind Bank exploring QIP option to raise funds, bring down govt holding: MD Saha

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi

Public sector lender Punjab & Sind Bank is exploring raising funds through various means, including the QIP route to dilute the government's stake to meet Sebi's minimum public shareholding (MPS) norms.

As per the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), all listed companies must maintain an MPS of 25 per cent.

"We have got board approval for fundraising through qualified institutional placement (QIP) and others means as part of effort to bring down the Government holding in a phased manner," Punjab & Sind Bank MD and CEO Swarup Kumar Saha told PTI in an interview.

Besides, he said, the bank has on boarded merchant bankers and legal advisors for the same. The proposed fundraise may happen this financial year depending on market conditions, he added.

Currently, the government holds a 93.85 per cent stake in Delhi-headquartered Punjab & Sind Bank. This is the highest stake of the Government of India in any public sector bank.

Three other banks have a minimum public shareholding of less than 25 per cent - Chennai-based Indian Overseas Bank where government holding is 92.44 per cent followed by Kolkata-based UCO Bank at 90.95 per cent, and Mumbai-based Central Bank of India at 81.19 per cent.

Even the special dispensa-

tion deadline given by the government for meeting minimum public shareholding norms for central public sector enterprises and public sector financial institutions is ending in 2026.

It would most likely be extended by another two years as government entities would not be able to meet the MPS norms during this month. In a bid to establish an international banking business presence, Punjab & Sind Bank is planning to operationalise an IFSC Banking Unit (IBU) at GIFT City in Gandhinagar by November this year.

The bank has received regulatory approvals from both the Reserve Bank of India and the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) to set up an IBU, Saha said.

"The IBU is going to act as a foreign branch, and this will provide a lot of scope for expanding business in terms of mobilisation of Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) and External Commercial Borrowings. This branch will help expand our balance sheet size and we also intend to bring in foreign exchange business," he said.

STATE INFRASTRUCTURE & INDUSTRIAL DEVELOPMENT CORPORATION OF UTTARAKHAND LTD.

29, IIE, SAHASTRADHARA ROAD (IT PARK), DEHRADUN

Ph No. 0135-2607292, 0135-2708100 Web Site : www.siidcul.com

NIT No.01/2026-27

Invitation of Applications

Date:14.08.2026

Applications are invited for Allotment of available industrial plots in Integrated Industrial Estates of SIIDCUL, which can be filled online through <https://investuttarakhand.uk.gov.in> during 17/08/2026 to 02/09/2026, 17:00 Hrs. Detailed document can be downloaded from website of SIIDCUL www.siidcul.com. Further any corrigendum regarding the advertisement shall be published in website www.siidcul.com only. Interested applicants can only submit the complete application on website <https://investuttarakhand.uk.gov.in> on/ before mentioned due date.

Managing Director

उत्तराखण्ड सीड्स एण्ड तराई डेवलपमेंट कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड

पंतनगर, पत्थरचट्टा पो-हल्दी-263 145, जमपद : कृष्ण सिंह नगर

रसाइट : www.pantnagarseeds.com & www.ukstcdc.com Email: tdc@uaseedsandtdc.com

यातायात ई-निविदा सूचना MKT/02/2026-27

निगम के पंतनगर, खटीमा एवं धनौरी (हरिद्वार) स्थित बीज संयंत्रों / गोदामों से स्थानीय एवं देश के विभिन्न स्थानों को बीजों का परिवहन, लाने, उतारने एवं गोदामों में भण्डारण व्यवस्था हेतु ई-निविदा के माध्यम से दो बिड व्यवस्था के अन्तर्गत निविदादाताओं से निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र का मूल्य रु० 2000.00 + (जी०एस०टी० 18 प्रतिशत कुल धनराशि रु० 2360.00) जमा करने के उपरान्त दिनांक 17.08.2026 से दिनांक 30.08.2026 सांय 5:00 बजे तक ई-निविदाएं www.uktenders.gov.in पर भरी जा सकती है। ई-निविदा प्रपत्र, आवश्यक अर्हताएं एवं अन्य शर्तें निगम की वेबसाइट: www.pantnagarseeds.com - www.ukstcdc.com पर भी उपलब्ध है। अधिक जानकारी हेतु निम्न मोबाइल नम्बर पर सम्पर्क किया जा सकता है।

1. विपणन अधिकारी मो०-9410561705

2. सहा० विपणन अधिकारी मो०-9415205727

प्रबन्ध निदेशक

उत्तराखण्ड सीड्स एण्ड तराई डेवलपमेंट कॉर्पोरेशन लिमिटेड

पंतनगर, पत्थरचट्टा पो-हल्दी-263 145, जमपद : कृष्ण सिंह नगर

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ई-निविदा सूचना

निगम के उत्तराखण्ड राज्य स्थित संयंत्रों व गोदामों पर उपलब्ध गेहूँ बीज व अन्य फसलों के बीजों के छानन, झाड़न (अनुपचारित) मात्रा लगभग 1267.94 कुन्तल "जहां है, जैसे है" के आधार पर विक्रय हेतु उपलब्ध है। उपलब्ध समस्त मात्रा अथवा आंशिक मात्रा का टेण्डर भरा जा सकता है। जिसका मूल्य रु० 2,000.00 + 18 प्रतिशत जी०एस०टी० अतिरिक्त नगद जमा कर अथवा उक्त राशि का आर० टी० जी० एस०/एन० ई० एफ० टी० अलग से ई-निविदा प्रपत्र के साथ संगनम करना अनिवार्य है। निविदा वेबसाइट www.uktenders.gov.in के माध्यम से दिनांक 17.08.2026 से 30.08.2026 के सांय 5:00 बजे तक भरी जायेगी। निविदा प्रपत्र के साथ कुल बीज मात्रा के मूल्य के सपेक्ष घरोहर धनराशि का आर०टी०जी० एस०/एन०ई०एफ०टी० अथवा बैंक ड्राफ्ट दिनांक 30.08.2026 तक सांय 5:00 बजे तक निगम मुख्यालय पत्थरचट्टा (हल्दी) पर जमा किया जायेगा। ई-निविदा दिनांक 31.08.2026 को अपरान्ह 3:00 बजे अधिकृत समिति द्वारा खोली जायेगी। अधिक जानकारी निगम के वेबसाइट: www.ukstcdc.com एवं www.pantnagarseeds.com पर उपलब्ध है। ई-निविदा को www.uktenders.gov.in पर देखा एवं भरा जा सकता है।

प्रबन्ध निदेशक

BRIEFLY

British Indian Amit Bhatia-led consortium agrees to acquire minority stake in Liverpool FC



Premier League side Liverpool FC has entered into a “definitive agreement” to sell a minority equity stake to a consortium led and managed by British-Indian businessman Amit Bhatia, with Amazon founder Jeff Bezos among the prominent investors.

The 46-year-old Bhatia, son-in-law of Indian steel magnate Lakshmi Mittal, leads and manages 1892 Holdings, which also includes K5 Sports, a K5 Global Fund with Bezos as its lead investor, and EE Capital, the family office of Elaine and Facebook co-founder Eduardo Saverin.

“Fenway Sports Group (FSG), a global sports, media, entertainment and real estate company, today announced that it has entered into a definitive agreement for the sale of a minority equity stake in Liverpool FC to 1892 Holdings,” a club statement read. Existing owners Fenway Sports Group, however, will retain majority ownership and operational control of Liverpool, with the strategic investment aimed at supporting the club’s long-term growth ambitions. “We are incredibly proud to be investing in Liverpool Football Club and to be doing so alongside FSG. We have the utmost respect and admiration for FSG as owners and for everything they have achieved at Anfield,” Bhatia said in a statement. (PTI)

Paris Saint-Germain signs Mika Godts from Ajax



Champions League titleholder Paris Saint-Germain strengthened its attack even further by signing left winger Mika Godts from Dutch club Ajax on a five-year deal. PSG announced the transfer late on Saturday without giving any financial details. Sports daily L’Equipe estimated the fee to be 55 million euros (\$64 million) including bonuses. It was the second signing of the day after Spain’s World Cup-winning forward Ferran Torres joined from Barcelona for a reported fee of 50 million euros.

The 21-year-old Godts came through the youth ranks at Anderlecht before joining Genk and then Ajax. He played for the Amsterdam-based club’s highly rated youth team, Jong Ajax, before breaking into the senior side.

In his first full season, the right-footer scored eight goals in 47 matches overall and made an impression in the Europa League. Last season, he stepped up a level with 17 goals and 15 assists in 44 matches and broke into the Belgium side.

“I can’t wait to pull on this (PSG) shirt and experience the Parc des Princes and its supporters,” Godts said. “I’ll give my all on the pitch to repay the faith placed in me.” (AP)

Formula E keen to return but India need to have the will to host: Longo

AMANPREET SINGH ■ London

Formula E is keen to return to India but is waiting for an Indian city to make the first move, championship co-founder Alberto Longo said, three years after the all-electric series made a promising Hyderabad debut but was dropped from the calendar amid contractual and political issues.

The all-electric world championship made its India debut with the Hyderabad E-Prix in February 2023, but the race was dropped the following year after a change of government in Telangana, with the new administration deciding not to fulfil the Host City Agreement signed by the previous dispensation. Promoter Greenko also withdrew as the multi-year arrangement got complicated.

Longo said Formula E remains



eager to return to what he considers one of the world’s most important markets for electric mobility.

“We would love to go back to India. Unfortunately, I have to tell you that we don’t have any live con-

versation at the moment, but it’s such an important market for Formula E that we would absolutely love to be back there,” Longo told PTI in an interview during the London season finale. Asked what

needed to happen for India to return to the calendar, Longo said Formula E was ready to engage but wanted an invitation from an Indian city or authorities.

“There needs to be a will to host a Formula E event. Trust me, we are really ready to come back to India. We are discussing with more than 80 cities worldwide today simultaneously. Unfortunately, we don’t have anyone from India knocking at our door, and that is what needs to change, the willingness of the Indian cities to host a Formula E event,” Formula E CEO Jeff Dadds echoed the same sentiment and hopes the country could return to the calendar in the coming seasons.

“We have a number of very, very high profile Indian partners. Obviously Mahindra up there, Infosys is a big partner of ours, Tata obvious-

ly own the Jaguar racing team, Tata and TCS Jaguar. So we have a number of very important Indian partners,” Dadds said. “And the growth coming out of India and the EV potential in India is absolutely enormous. So India remains a priority market for us. Our ambition is to return to race in India. We have to find the right opportunity between the street circuit,” he said. “Now traditionally we’ve raced on street circuits. The Gen 4 car makes that much more complicated because we need surfaces and circuits that allow the car to stretch its legs.”

Dadds added: “I would be very, very optimistic over the coming seasons that you’ll see us return to India. Not exactly sure where.” Longo said the economic impact of a Formula E race was another reason Indian cities could consider bringing the championship back. (PTI)

Scheffler settles with 68 builds two-shot lead over Burns and Sungjae in Memphis

DOUG FERGUSON ■ Memphis (USA)

Scottie Scheffler settled in after a rough start Saturday for a 2-under 68, giving him a two-shot lead over Sam Burns and Sungjae Im in the FedEx St. Jude Championship going into a final round where so much is at stake from the top to the bottom of the leaderboard. Scheffler is trying to break a streak of five runner-up finishes and five other top 4s since his lone victory this year in his first tournament of 2026.

He was at 13-under 197 and will be in the final group with Burns, his closest friend in golf, who got back into the mix with a 62. His year has been marked by close calls in the U.S. Open and British Open,

but Burns has no victories to show for it. This will be the first time they are paired together in the final group.

“It’s always a little weird just because I want him to have success so much and I think he wants the same for me,” Scheffler said. “Tomorrow we’ll go out there and play our game and see where things finish up at the end of the day. It will be competition like normal. “It will be fun being out there with your friend but it’s also a bit weird at the same time.”

And it’s not just the two of them. Im shot 67 and was tied with Burns at 11-under 199. The next closest to Scheffler was FedEx Cup champion Tommy Fleetwood (68) and Jake Knapp (67), both five shots

Hockey WC: India face acid test against England

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ Amstelveen

India will face their toughest challenge in the FIH Men’s Hockey World Cup pool stage when they take on world No.3-ranked England on Monday. The 32-year wait for a World Cup win over their European rivals adds an extra edge to the crucial Pool D clash.

India began their campaign with a 3-1 win over lower-ranked Wales on Saturday, with captain Harmanpreet Singh converting two penalty corners and Sanjay also finding the net from a set piece.

England will present a significantly tougher examina-

tion after opening their campaign with an impressive 4-1 win over Pakistan.

The result has made Monday’s contest particularly important under the new World Cup format. The top two teams from each pool will advance to the second stage, regrouped as Pools E and F. The result against the team they have already played in the first round is carried forward, which could prove decisive in the race for the semifinals.

With both India and England eyeing the top two positions in Pool D, the outcome could have a major bearing on their route to the knockout stages.

India will also look to



improve on an otherwise satisfactory opening performance against Wales. The forward line, especially Abhishek and Sukhjeet, created chances but could not finish from open play, leaving the team heavily reliant on set pieces. India

started well against Wales, scoring two goals in the first quarter itself, but after that, there was a visible drop in intensity, which could prove costly in the matches ahead. India will need to address these weaker links against England, who are likely to

Rankings, past performances don’t matter in Ind-Pak match: Pak hockey captain Bakar

MONA PARTHSARATHI ■ Amstelveen

The Pakistan hockey team has failed to beat India for more than a decade, but captain Abu Bakar Mahmood is confident of ending that streak at the FIH World Cup, insisting that when arch-rivals meet, rankings matter little and it is the team that performs better on the day that prevails.

India will face Pakistan in the FIH WC on August 19. India defeated Wales 3-1 in the opening match, while England thrashed Pakistan 4-1 in another pool D match.

“I have no hesitation in accepting that the Indian



team is much better than us in rankings, but in the India-Pakistan match, rankings don’t matter. The performance on that day is important... It will only be decided on the day of the match which team is playing well and will win,”

Mahmood said. The Pakistan senior men’s hockey team last defeated India 4-3 in the Champions Trophy in London in June 2016. India recently defeated Pakistan 4-3 and 7-1 in the London leg of the FIH Pro League. (PTI)

Hunger towards the game as strong as it was when I began my career: Sindhu

SAUMOJYOTI S CHOUDHURY ■ New Delhi

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu is eyeing a historic sixth World Championships medal, with the Indian star saying her “hunger towards the game” remains as strong as it was when she began her senior career at the age of 14 in 2009.

Sindhu is already a five-time World Championships medallist, having won two bronze medals, two silver medals and a gold in 2019. A semifinal appearance at the marquee event, which begins here on Monday, would assure her of at least a bronze and make her the first player in the history of the championships to win six medals.

Only two other players have won five World Championships medals —

China’s Lin Dan, who collected five men’s singles golds, and compatriot Zhao Yunlei, who won three mixed doubles and two women’s doubles titles.

“I’m very excited and looking forward to getting a lot of support from the Indian crowd. This World Championships is special because it is happening in India after 17 years. Hope I will get a medal here,” Sindhu said at a pre-event press conference on Sunday.

“I would say and I think each win or medal gave me a different kind of experience. Having five medals at the World Championships is an amazing journey. The transition has been in such a way that it is wonderful. Getting a medal itself is an amazing moment.

“I just have to go out there



and put my best out there irrespective of the result. The hunger towards the game hasn’t changed. I know it is in me and I can still do it. I am much more experienced and stronger than my first World Championships,” a confident Sindhu added.

The 31-year-old is brimming with confidence after recently ending her nearly two-year title drought by

winning the Japan Open.

“Yes, it was a long wait but the Japan Open gave me confidence ahead of the World Championships. Definitely, after winning the Japan Open, that gave me a lot of boost.

“I think physically and mentally it has been quite good. I am able to see the changes in terms of my game and my movement. I am happy it is going in the right

way,” Sindhu said. Sindhu did not deny that there would be pressure and expectations when she opens her women’s singles campaign against Ireland’s Sophia Noble on Monday. “There will be butterflies because I don’t deny that there is no pressure, there is pressure. There is nothing to lose, I just want to give my best. I have trained hard and will just try to give my best on the court.”

The star shuttler admitted that badminton has changed and evolved significantly over the years and said the new 15-point scoring system, which will be introduced next year, will present a fresh challenge. “Quite a few changes in terms of game, in terms of how you think and strategise. Badminton as a sport itself has changed. Earlier women’s singles was more of attack-

offer far fewer opportunities and punish defensive lapses. Harmanpreet was influential at both ends of the pitch against Wales, but India will expect greater coordination and sharper finishing from its forwards. The two teams had a closely-fought encounter in the London leg of the Pro League before the World Cup, with both sides winning a penalty shootout and earning bonus points.

England, however, come into the tournament with strong recent form. They lost only two of their 16 matches in the 2025-26 Pro League and finished runners-up behind Belgium, while India finished eighth among nine teams.

Asked about India’s Pro



national team won the World Cup. Defending champion Barcelona and Jose Mourinho’s Real Madrid won’t start their campaigns until next weekend because they had players return late from the World Cup.

League struggles, Harmanpreet had said the team was focused on the World Cup. “There are ups and downs in the game, but our focus is currently on the World Cup. We have come well prepared and the team is in form. We will focus on taking it match by match and creating as many scoring opportunities as possible,” he said. India will also hope that the three-day training camp in Switzerland before the tournament helps them handle the pressure of high-stakes matches. England have been among the consistent contenders at the World Cup, reaching at least the final five in each of the last five editions since 2006. (PTI)

Barcelona, chasing a third straight Spanish league crown, visits Elche on Aug. 23. Madrid, revamped under Mourinho after a second consecutive season without a major title, starts at Espanyol on Aug. 22. (AP)

ing, more fast-paced but now it’s more of long rallies and more time on court. So you need more patience now,” Sindhu said.

“The new scoring system it is going to be very challenging. If it is 21 points there is still time to recover even if you are 0-7 down but in 15 you are gone.

“You need to be on your feet from point one - you can’t take it easy and comebacks will be difficult.” The World Championships are returning to the country after 17 years since Hyderabad hosted the event in 2009. The New Delhi edition is also under the spotlight after a difficult India Open earlier this year, when concerns over air quality, venue hygiene, bird droppings and incidents involving stray animals attracted considerable attention. (PTI)

Lani stuns Ledecy with her first international 800 free loss at Pan Pacific



BETH HARRIS ■ Irvine (USA)

Lani Pallister of Australia stunned Katie Ledecy with her first international loss in the 800-meter freestyle at the Pan Pacific Championships on Saturday night.

Pallister was under world-record pace for much of the race and touched in 8 minutes, 6.10 seconds to erase Ledecy’s championship record from 2018.

“I was just so locked in and I’ve been really focused on what I want,” Pallister said. “The 800 is my favorite event.” Ledecy took silver in a season-best 8:07.26.

“That was definitely my best swim of the week, so I’m actually pretty happy with it,” she said. “If I was going to get second tonight, I wanted to make it a good one. Just wanted to make it hard for Lani.” Ledecy is the four-time Olympic champion in her signature event. The American’s lone previous defeat in an 800 free final since 2010 came in a small domestic meet in February

2024 against Summer McIntosh of Canada.

“Katie’s such a dominant force,” a breathless Pallister said after the race.

Kate Douglass lowered her own world record in the 50 free for the second time Saturday, winning the final in 23.19 - one of three events on the final night. “I was doubting myself, questioning my ability to do the triple,” she said. “My coaches and my teammates just really had a lot of faith in me and they really gave me a lot of energy.” In the morning preliminaries, the 24-year-old American swam 23.49 to take the mark away from teammate Gretchen Walsh, who finished second in the evening final in 23.74.

Douglass returned 25 minutes later to finish second in the 200 breaststroke. She rallied from third down the stretch but couldn’t catch Alexanne Lepage of Canada, who led the entire race and touched in a lifetime best of 2:21.73. Douglass finished in 2:22.57. (AP)

1st Test: Padikkal, Jurel carry India to 460/9 on day two

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Galle

Devidutt Padikkal's sophisticated 167 was the centrepiece in India's strong 460 for nine at stumps despite the Sri Lankan spinners growing fangs on a truncated second day of the first Test here on Sunday. Kuldeep Yadav (12) and Prasidh Krishna (1) were batting at close.

Rains of varying intensity and the resultant wet outfield delayed the start of the day's play until 2.35 pm, and the long break seemed to have rejuvenated the Lankans more. The home bowlers produced better lines and lengths than day one, cutting down the

scoring areas of Indian batters, who resumed from a far stronger 288 for two. It was the perfect launching pad to be in a far healthier position, but the tourists lost seven wickets - some to the Lankan spinners' guile and some to their own indiscretions — for 172 runs. Padikkal, who started from 131, brought up his maiden 150 in 215 balls when he pulled pacer Asitha Fernando for a boundary.

However, before the left-hander reached his landmark, India had lost the other overnight batter Rishabh Pant for 39. Pant seemed impatient to stamp his authority over the bowlers, but the overzeal-

ousness ended his stint, as a feeble loft off off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha was snafled by a running-in Sonal Dinusha.

KL Rahul, who had to retire on 77 because of cramps the previous day, walked in next but could only add four more runs to his overnight score.

Rahul failed to negotiate the turn and bounce from Nuwantha, giving a simple catch to Nishan Madhushka at short leg. Capturing two big wickets by giving away just 12 runs put a spring on Lankan bowlers' steps and the hosts added the big wicket of Padikkal at the stroke of tea to further boost their standing. The left-



hander was deceived on flight by left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya and stumper Niroshan Dickwella did the rest. However, the bigwigs will be delighted to see the way Padikkal responded to the task of occupying a crucial slot like No. 3. It has given them another option even when original resident Sai Sudharsan returns from his toe injury. India went to tea at 364 for five, and needed a few more runs to really pull away from Sri Lanka.

Ravindra Jadeja was trapped leg before by Nuwantha immediately after the break, leaving India at 377 for six. But Jurel, who was struggling for runs of

late, rose to the occasion to play a nifty innings. There was a huge slice of fortune as Lankan skipper Dhananjaya de Silva grassed Jurel's healthy edge off Jayasuriya at the first slip.

The right-hander was on 29 then, and went past fifty soon for the first time in eight innings. It was a fluent innings as well, lifting Nuwantha for a six over mid-wicket and then pulling an expensive Lahiru Kumara for a boundary. However, Jurel, who added 55 runs for the seventh wicket with Manav Suthar (24), did not stay back to convert his fifty into something bigger.

De Silva took a flying catch at slip off Jayasuriya to atone

for his earlier slip-up. But by then India, despite losing wickets, have reached firm grounds with Mohammad Siraj and Suthar producing some heavy blows. From a Sri Lankan perspective, the home think-tank would have been massively disappointed with two pacers —Kumara and Fernando—who neither were very effective in taking wickets nor contained runs when it was needed. The knock by Suthar will also please the team management as skipper Shubman Gill had underscored the need for late order batters to chip in with some runs in absence of injured all-rounders like Washington Sundar. (P77)

Rahul sets early tone in SL with adaptive mind and preparation against spin

G UNNIKRIISHNAN ■ Galle

KL Rahul made a little shimmy to reach the ball, unfurled his wrist and executed a picture perfect cover drive, leaving Prabath Jayasuriya smiling wistfully on the opening day of the first Test here.

It was a personal statement of his authority over Sri Lanka's premier bowler.

But it also reflected India's newfound confidence against tweakers after setbacks at home against New Zealand and South African slow bowlers dimmed their aura. In a way it was in the fitness of things that the senior most batter in this Indian team took it upon himself the task of stonewalling the Lankan spinners. But Rahul went through extensive preparations before crossing the Palk Strait at the Wings Sports Centre in Mumbai managed by former India player and selector Jatin Paranjape. His India teammate Yashasvi Jaiswal too trained there, focusing on tackling the Lankan spin armada.



Rahul's early coach Samuel Jayaraj was not surprised one bit.

"He has always been a meticulous person, strong in his mind and technique. But more than that he is always willing to learn and

adapt. Once he gets a good start, Rahul knows how to capitalise on it. For him, I think, it was all about sustaining his concentration for a longer period. Now, he is a lot better at rotating strike too," Jayaraj

said. The Karnataka batter's half-century in the ongoing Galle Test was a testament to it. Rahul has consumed 162 balls for his 77 before retiring due to cramps, and his strike-rate of 47.53 is the slowest among all the Indian batters who batted on Day 1.

But the comfort offered by the presence of a solid batter at the other end helped others like Devdutt Padikkal (SR: 73.59) or Jaiswal (SR: 86.48) engage in free-flowing batting. It may look a tad boring to watch Rahul batting in tranquil mode, when he actually can dominate the bowlers with some twinkling shots.

But as an opener, Rahul values the team's cause more than making an individual style statement.

India's batting coach Sitanshu Kotak underlined the responsibility Rahul was willing to shoulder for the team. "He is someone, when he plays in one-day (match) as you have seen him, he bats at number 6 or 5. So, when you are a

senior batsman, and if you are open to bat at any number and help the team, I think that is a great player to have.

"So for a team, he is someone who is very useful. In a red ball match he opens, in a one-day match he bats wherever required. Now, the way he is batting, he is taking a lot of responsibilities, he is trying to create a lot of partnerships, and that is something really good to have, and he has been very, very consistent," said Kotak.

Consistency is the key word here. In the current World Test Championship cycle (2024-2027), Rahul is currently at sixth with 873 runs from 10 Tests, averaging over 54 with three hundreds.

Among the Indian batters, only skipper Shubman Gill has scored more runs than him - 966 from nine matches with five hundreds.

Possibly, Rahul is also relishing his role as the batting fulcrum after the departure of Virat Kohli, Cheteshwar Pujara and Ajinkya Rahane from the Test side. (P77)

Bangladesh claims first win in Australia with 9-wicket victory in 1st Test

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Darwin (Australia)

Bangladesh completed a stunning nine-wicket victory over Australia in the first test on Sunday, securing its first win on Australian soil and only its second victory over top-ranked Australia.

After making a vital half-century with the bat, Mehidy Hasan Miraz took five wickets for Bangladesh in the second innings to restrict Australia to a lead of just 56 runs, as the hosts were bowled out for 284 midway through the afternoon session at Darwin's Marrara Oval.

Bangladesh suffered some early nerves in its chase when Josh Hazlewood (1-5) dismissed first-innings centurion Tanzid Hasan for a duck, but Shadman Islam (25 not out) and Mominul Haque (30 not out) held their composure to reach the target in 14.2 overs sparking wild celebrations within the contingent of Bangladesh fans seated behind the team's dugout on the boundary.

"This is the biggest win so far for Bangladesh in any format," Bangladesh captain Najmul Hossain Shanto said.

"We will do something special in the future."

The victory was celebrated back home, too, with Shanto taking a congratulatory



video call from Bangladesh Prime Minister Tarique Rahman in the dressing room.

"These are special moments for us, as I believe everyone back home is enjoying our success," Shanto said in comments on the espn-cricinfo website. "We get these moments very few times in our life, so we should spend the whole day in celebrating this win."

Cameron Green scored his third test century, and his first in Australia, making a composed 104 from 201 balls to lead Australia's resistance.

It was a thoroughly deserved result for Bangladesh, which had outplayed Australia for much of the test after home captain Pat Cummins won the toss

and elected to bat. Australia managed just 198 in its first innings, with man-of-the-match Hasan Mahmud taking 6-55, before Bangladesh capitalized as the pitch flattened to post 426 and take a commanding 228-run lead.

That advantage ultimately proved too much for Australia to overcome, despite Green's breakthrough century, as Bangladesh secured a historic victory, and only its second against Australia after its maiden win in Dhaka, Bangladesh in 2017.

For Australia, the defeat will rank as one of its most humiliating home reverses in its 149-year test history with considerable pressure now on the team's selectors to make changes ahead of the second test in Mackay, Queensland state, starting Aug. 22.

"I think every time there's a game like this, you always look at your match-ups and your make-up with the team for the next one," Cummins said.

"We're pretty good at bouncing back, so no doubt the batters and every group will get together and have a good think about this one and where we can improve."

With the door still ajar for Australia at 161-4 at the start of Day 4 with Green and Alex Carey at the crease, Mehidy (5-66) firmly closed it with a superb spell either side of lunch to claim four more wickets, to accompany the huge wicket of Steve Smith late on Day 3 to turn the match decisively for Bangladesh.

Pak retain Wahab Riaz as women's team head coach for Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lahore

The Pakistan Cricket Board has retained head coach Wahab Riaz and the other coaches of the national women's squad for the forthcoming Asia Cup in the UAE and the Asian Games in Japan. In another surprising call, the selectors have recalled senior batter Aliya Riaz for the Asian Games, even though she has not performed well since being dropped for the tour of Sri Lanka following a poor ICC T20 World Cup.

The selectors have also again ignored two top batters, Sidra Amin and Sadaf Shams, for both the T20 tournaments, as both have been deemed to be only ODI players. Sidra scored a



hundred in the ODI series that Pakistan lost in Sri Lanka.

Pakistan lost both the ODI and T20 series in Sri Lanka and, before that, finished with just one win in the T20 World Cup under the management of Wahab, batting coach Imran Farhat,

bowling coach Abdul Rehman and Umaid Asif. Regular captain Fatima Sana will lead the team in both tournaments after skipping the Sri Lanka T20I series due to her commitments with The Hundred.

The eight-team Women's Asia Cup is set to be played from August 28 to September 13 at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium, with Pakistan placed in Group A alongside Hong Kong-China, India and Thailand.

Group B consists of Bangladesh, Indonesia, Sri Lanka and the United Arab Emirates. At the Asian Games in Japan, Pakistan are seeded alongside Thailand and will play them in the September 17 quarterfinal.



समस्त प्रदेशवासियों को स्वतंत्रता दिवस की हार्दिक शुभकामनाएँ

मण्डी का यही प्रयास उत्तराखण्ड का हो समग्र विकास



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